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Titus

Titus 1:1

Section 1:1–4: Greetings

In New Testament times, when a Christian wrote a letter, he usually began with three things. He wrote his own name and the name of anyone else who was sending the letter. Then he wrote the name of the person or people to whom he was sending the letter. And then he would give a Christian greeting. Paul included all three of these elements in his letter to Titus:

- In 1:1–3, Paul introduced himself as the writer of the letter.
- In 1:4a, he named Titus as the person receiving the letter.
- 1:4b contains Paul's Christian greeting to Titus.

When people in your area write letters, they may use a different order. Perhaps they put the name of the writer at the end, as we do in English. However, when you translate Titus, you should keep the name of the writer, the name of the one receiving the letter, and the greeting in the opening section. Once you have decided on the best and most natural way to do this in your language, follow that way in all of Paul's letters.

In Greek this section is one long sentence. Some English versions also translate it as just one sentence. However, you will probably want to break it up into several sentences as you try to express all the different ideas that Paul mentioned.

1:1a

Paul, a servant of God

- ¶ This letter is from Paul. I am a slave/servant of God
- ¶ I, Paul, am writing this letter. I serve God,

Paul: The apostle Paul was the writer of this letter. He began the letter with his name. In some languages it is not natural for a person to refer to himself only by his name, as Paul did here. If that is the case in your language, you may want to say:

I, Paul

Paul did not use a verb here. In some languages, it may be natural to supply a verb. For example:

I, Paul, am sending/writing this letter

This letter is from me, Paul

a servant of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant normally refers to an unpaid servant or slave. Paul said that he was God's slave. This implied that he belonged to God and that he served God by doing what God told him to do.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a slave of God (NET)

a worker of/for God

I serve God

1:1b

and an apostle of Jesus Christ

- and an apostle of Jesus Christ.
- and I have been sent by Jesus Christ.

an apostle of Jesus Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as an apostle means "a messenger" or "a person who is sent on a mission." It refers to a person who is given authority to do a task or give a message. This person represents the person who sent him and has his authority. In this context, Paul was sent by Jesus Christ to represent him and do the task that Jesus gave him.

Here are some ways to translate the phrase an apostle of Jesus Christ:

a person sent to speak/act on behalf of Jesus Christ

a special messenger from Jesus Christ

a representative of Jesus Christ

a man with authority from Jesus Christ

See how you translated apostle in Romans 1:1b, 1 Corinthians 1:1a and 1 Timothy 1:1b. Translate here in the same way that you did there. Be careful to choose different terms for "apostle," "angel," "elder," and "prophet."

of Jesus Christ: In the phrase Jesus Christ, Jesus is a personal name and Christ is a title. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah." Your translation should not imply that Christ is a surname.

To make it clear that Christ is a title, you may want to:

- Put the title before the name. For example:

Christ Jesus

- Translate it as “Messiah” or “the Messiah.” For example:

Messiah Jesus

Jesus the Messiah

- Indicate in some other way that Christ is a title. One way to do this in English is to use the article “the” before a title. For example:

Jesus the Christ

1:1c

for the faith of God’s elect

- I have been sent to strengthen the faith of those whom God has chosen
- He sent me to help God’s chosen people trust/believe in him

for the faith of God’s elect: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* here probably indicates purpose. It introduces Jesus’ purpose in choosing Paul to be his apostle. Scholars have interpreted the phrase for the faith of God’s elect in at least two ways:

1. It means that Paul was made an apostle to help believers to believe more strongly in Jesus. For example:

to help the faith of God’s chosen people (NCV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, CEV, NCV, RSV)

1. It means that Paul was made an apostle in order to explain the gospel to people who were not yet believers, so that they would begin to believe. For example:

to lead God’s chosen people to faith (GW) (NJB, NLT, GW)

Both were Paul’s job, and we cannot be certain which one Paul was focusing on here. If you can translate this verse so that it can mean both things, you may do so. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because the term God’s elect most naturally refers to those who are already Christians. Of the two interpretations given for

1:1c, probably the first is closer to Paul’s meaning. In this letter to Titus, Paul talks about teaching believers true teachings and how believers should behave. So it is more likely that in 1:1c he is talking about helping believers to believe more strongly. Also, in other places in the NT, the word *elect* (Greek: *eklektos*) refers to people who are already believers (for example, see Colossians 3:12, 1 Peter 1:1–2, 2:9, Revelation 17:14).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to encourage the faith of God’s chosen ones

for the sake of the faith of God’s elect (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb and translate this as a complete sentence. For example:

I was sent to help the faith of God’s chosen people (NCV)

I encourage God’s own people to have more faith (CEV)

God’s elect: This phrase refers to the people whom God chose to believe in him and be his special people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

those chosen of God (NASB)

those chosen by God

the people whom God chose to be his own/special people

1:1d

and their knowledge of the truth

- and to increase their knowledge of what is true.
- and learn more about the true teaching/message.

and their knowledge of the truth: This phrase indicates the second purpose for which Paul was made an apostle. Paul was also made an apostle in order to help God’s chosen people know the truth better. The word *truth* refers to the gospel message, that is, the teachings of Christianity and the truth about Jesus Christ and his work.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and to strengthen their knowledge of the true things about Jesus

and to help them know the truth (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

I teach them to understand his true message
(EASY)

1:1e that leads to godliness,

- This will teach/help them to live as God wants them to live.
- This true teaching/message will guide them to act/ behave in a way that honors/pleases God.

that leads to godliness: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness:

1. It means a way of life that pleases God. For example:

that shows people how to serve God (NCV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, RSV, NET, GW, NLT, NCV, KJV, NASB)

1. It means religion. For example:

taught by our religion (GNT) (GNT, CEV, NJB, REB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was saying that this true teaching causes people to behave in a way that honors God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that shows them how to live godly lives (NLT)

As a result they will live in a way that pleases God. (EASY)

Titus 1:2

Section 1:1–4: Greetings

In New Testament times, when a Christian wrote a letter, he usually began with three things. He wrote his own name and the name of anyone else who was sending the letter. Then he wrote the name of the person or people to whom he was sending the letter. And then he would give a Christian greeting. Paul

included all three of these elements in his letter to Titus:

- In 1:1–3, Paul introduced himself as the writer of the letter.
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When people in your area write letters, they may use a different order. Perhaps they put the name of the writer at the end, as we do in English. However, when you translate Titus, you should keep the name of the writer, the name of the one receiving the letter, and the greeting in the opening section. Once you have decided on the best and most natural way to do this in your language, follow that way in all of Paul's letters.

In Greek this section is one long sentence. Some English versions also translate it as just one sentence. However, you will probably want to break it up into several sentences as you try to express all the different ideas that Paul mentioned.

1:2a in the hope of eternal life,

- Then they will have the hope of eternal life. (CEV)
- As a result, they can have hope/confidence that they will live forever with God.

in the hope of eternal life: There are several ways to interpret how this phrase is connected to 1:1. The two main interpretationsHarold Greenlee's book, *An Exegetical Summary of Titus and Philemon*, lists several different ways to interpret the connection between 1:1 and the hope of eternal life in 1:2. There is also a discussion of this problem in the SSA (John Banker's book *Semantic Structure Analysis of Titus*). Some of the other interpretations are:(1) the hope of eternal life relates to the phrase "an apostle of Jesus Christ" in 1:1. It tells the purpose of Paul's work: "Jesus Christ made me his apostle so I could help God's chosen people to strongly believe in him, and so I could cause them to know the true teaching, **and so I could give them the hope of eternal life.**"(2) the hope of eternal life is the basis for Paul's being an apostle: "I am an apostle of Jesus Christ...**because I have the hope of eternal life.**"(3) the hope of eternal life is the basis for us having faith and knowledge. "We have faith in Jesus and know the truth **because we have the hope of eternal life.**" are:

1. The hope of eternal life is the purpose or result of the faith and knowledge mentioned in 1:1c-d. For example:

Then they will have the hope of eternal life. (CEV)
(NJB, CEV, NLT)

1. The hope of eternal life is the basis or grounds of this faith and knowledge. For example:

which is based on the hope for eternal life (GNT)
(NIV84, GNT, NCV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Although interpretation (2) is possible from the Greek, normally in the NT eternal life is the result of faith. It is the ultimate goal of believing in Jesus and knowing his truth.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Because of their faith and knowledge, they hope to live forever.

This truth gives them confidence that they have eternal life (NLT)

the hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “confident hope” or “waiting for and expecting something to happen.” Christians can know for certain that God will do what he has promised. They can believe what he has said without any doubt. In English the word hope often indicates that we are not sure that something will happen. For instance, when we say “I hope that it rains,” it means that we want it to rain but we do not know if it will. This is not the Greek meaning of the word.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the expectation

they are certain/sure

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to life in God’s kingdom. This life continues forever.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

life forever

life that does not end

In some languages it may be best to translate life as a verb. For example:

they will live eternally

they will live with God forever

1:2b

which God, who cannot lie, promised before time began.

- God, who never lies, promised this eternal life before time/history began.
- Before anything in this world happened, God promised that his people would live forever. And he does not lie.

which God, who cannot lie, promised before time began: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as God, who cannot lie is more literally “the non-lying God.” The adjective “non-lying” describes God as one who does not say anything that is false. He only speaks the truth.

Here are some ways to translate this verse part:

which God, the one who does not lie, promised before the beginning of time

which God promised before the beginning of time. And he does not lie.

God does not lie. He promised this eternal life before the beginning of the world.

before time began: This phrase refers to the time before God made the world.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

before the world began (GW)

before the word was/existed

before he created the world (T4T)

Titus 1:3

Section 1:1–4: Greetings

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1:3a

In His own time He has made His word evident

- And at the right time, he revealed his word/message
- When God decided that the time was right, he made his gospel message known

In His own time He has made His word evident: The Greek text is more literally “at his appointed season he has brought to light his word.” Scholars have understood this clause in two ways:

1. At the right time God brought to light his word, that is, the gospel message. This is the message referred to as “the truth” in 1:1d. For example:

who indeed at the proper time revealed his word (NRSV) (BSB, NIV84, NRSV, NET, KJV, NJB, NABRE)

1. At the right time God brought to light the hope of eternal life mentioned in 1:2a. For example:

At the right time God let the world know about that life (NCV) (NIV, GNT, NCV, REB, ESV)

Some versions remain ambiguous or equate the two options. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The object of the Greek clause is “his word” and not “the hope of eternal life” from 1:2b.1:3 The majority of commentators support this understanding of the text. See Towner, Longman, Knight, Marshall, Collins, and Yarbrough.

In His own time: The phrase In His own time means “at the time that God chose.” The revelation of God’s word happened at the right time, at the time that God chose for it to be revealed.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at the proper time (CEV)

at just the right time (NLT)

He has made His word evident: The phrase made... evident here means “revealed.” It indicates that God made something clearly known to people. He made His word, that is, his message, the gospel message, known through Paul.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he has revealed this message (NLT)

he made his Word known (JBP)

God has caused people to know his gospel message

1:3b

in the proclamation entrusted to me by the command of God our Savior.

- by means of the proclamation that God our^(incl) Savior commanded me to declare/preach.
- through my preaching. This is the responsibility/task that God, the one who saves us, gave me.

in the proclamation entrusted to me: Paul’s proclamation was the means by which God revealed his word (1:3a). The content of that proclamation had been entrusted to Paul, that is, God gave him the responsibility of defending and proclaiming the gospel message. In this way God caused people to know this message.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

through the preaching with which I have been entrusted (ESV)

He did this through the preaching that he trusted me with. (NIRV)

He gave me the work of declaring that word/message.

entrusted to me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as entrusted here indicates that God gave Paul an important task or responsibility and expected him to do it well.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

He trusted me with that work (NCV)

he gave it to me

he gave me the responsibility for it

by the command of God our Savior: The Greek word that the BSB translates as command is a strong word that refers to a command/order issued by a superior person.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

by order of God our Savior (GNT)

God commanded me to do this.

God our Savior: The pronoun our is inclusive of Titus and all Christian believers.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate the word Savior as a phrase. For example:

God, the one who saves us^(incl) from sin

General Comment on 1:3b

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of information in this verse part. For example:

It is by the command of God our Savior that I have been entrusted with this work for him. (NLT)

General Comment on 1:1–3

In the Greek, Titus 1:1–3 forms one long sentence. In many languages it will be natural to translate these verses as several shorter sentences. For example:

^{1a}This letter is from me, Paul. I am God's servant
^{1b}and an apostle of Jesus Christ. ^{1c-d}God has sent me to help the people that he has chosen. I teach them to understand his true message and to trust him. ^{1e}As a result they will live in a way that pleases God. ^{2a-b}Before the world began, God promised that his people would have life with him. And God never tells lies. ^{3a-b}God is the one

who saves us. Now, at the proper time, he has made his message clear. He has given his message to me so that I can tell it to people. That is what he has told me to do. (EASY)

Titus 1:4

Section 1:1–4: Greetings

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In Greek this section is one long sentence. Some English versions also translate it as just one sentence. However, you will probably want to break it up into several sentences as you try to express all the different ideas that Paul mentioned.

1:4a

To Titus, my true child in our common faith:

- ¶ I write this letter to you, Titus. You are like my true son because of the faith that we^(incl/dual) share.
- ¶ I am writing to you, Titus. You are like my own son because we^(incl/dual) both believe the same thing.

To Titus, my true child: Paul now indicated to whom he was writing, that is, to whom his letter was addressed. Paul probably called Titus his true child because Paul had been responsible for him becoming a believer. The phrase also implies that Paul loved Titus as though he were his son.^{1:4} Some commentators say that the word true means that Titus was a loyal, faithful believer and Paul knew that he could depend on Titus. Only the NRSV has "my loyal child."

Titus was not actually Paul's child in the physical sense. In some languages it may be necessary to make

this explicit in order to avoid a wrong meaning. For example:

you are like my true son

it is as if you are my own son

you are like a son to me (CEV)

in our common faith: The Greek words that the BSB translates as our common faith mean “the faith that we have in common” or “the faith that we share.” Paul and Titus both believed in Jesus and in his gospel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the faith that we have in common (GNT)

the faith that we share (NLT)

because you believe the same teachings about God that I do (SSA)

1:4b

Grace and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior.

- May God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior give you grace and peace. (GNT)
- I pray to God our^(incl) Father and to Christ Jesus the one who saves us^(incl) to show you^(sing) kindness and give you peace.

Grace and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior: In the early days of Christianity, these words were a common Christian greeting. They form a blessing or prayer. Paul was asking God to bless Titus by giving him Grace and peace.

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb or verbs in this blessing. For example:

May God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior give you grace and peace. (GNT)

May you know/experience grace and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior.

May you receive grace from God the Father and live in peace through Christ Jesus our Savior.

In other languages it may be natural to translate one or both of the abstract nouns Grace or peace as verbs. For example:

I pray that God our Father and Christ Jesus our Savior will be kind to you and will bless you with peace! (CEV)

This greeting is similar to the greetings Paul used in other letters. See, for example, Romans 1:7d, Ephesians 1:2, and Philippians 1:2.

Grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grace means “kindness” or “favor.” Paul wanted God to show kindness and favor to Titus. See “grace”, sense A1, in KBT.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

kindness/goodness

favor

peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peace in this context refers to inner well-being. This sort of peace comes from being in relationship with God.

Even if you normally translate “grace” or peace as a long phrase, you may want to use something shorter in this greeting. Here Paul was not teaching about “grace” and peace. So it may not be necessary to include all the elements normally associated with these terms.

God the Father: In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this phrase as “God our^(incl) Father.” For example:

God our Father (CEV)

Christ Jesus: The phrase Christ Jesus has the same meaning as “Jesus Christ” (1:1b). If the people who read your translation will be confused by the different order of the words, you may use the more familiar order “Jesus Christ.”

Savior: This is the same word that Paul used in 1:3b. In 1:3b he called God “our Savior.” Here in 1:4b he uses the same title for Jesus. You should use the same term in both verses.

Titus 1:5

Section 1:5–9: Paul instructs Titus to appoint elders in the churches

In this section Paul began the main content of his letter, which continues through 3:11. He made a general statement about what he wanted Titus to do and then talked about how to choose men to be the leaders in the local churches. This section, especially 1:6–8, is very similar to 1 Timothy 3:1–7. If you have already translated 1 Timothy, you should compare your work there with the list here in Titus. Both lists talk about the character and behavior of elders in the church.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paul writes to Timothy concerning the appointment of church leaders

Instructions on how to select men to be elders in the churches

Qualifications for church leaders

1:5a

The reason I left you in Crete was

- ¶ I asked you to remain on the island of Crete
- ¶ When I left Crete, I asked you to stay there.

The reason I left you in Crete: This phrase introduces Paul's purpose in leaving Titus on the island of Crete. Some time before Paul wrote this letter, he had been on the island of Crete with Titus. At some point Paul had to leave to go somewhere else. He left Titus in charge of helping the new churches and teaching the believers. So here in 1:5 Paul was reminding Titus of things he had already told him some time before.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This is why I left you in Crete (RSV)

I left you in Crete, so that (GNT)

I left you in Crete: Paul asked Titus to stay in Crete to do a specific job. Avoid translating this in a way that suggests that Paul abandoned Titus without discussing it with him. It may be possible to translate this as:

When I left Crete, I asked you to remain there

In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

When I left Crete, I said to you, “I want you to stay here.”

Crete: Crete is a large island in the Mediterranean Sea. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

Crete island

the island of Crete

1:5b

that you would set in order what was unfinished

- so that you could continue doing the work that I had not had time to finish.
- I wanted you to organize the matters in the local churches that still needed attention.

was that you would set in order what was unfinished: This verse part tells the reason why Paul left Titus in Crete. Paul wanted Titus to put in order some things that had not yet been completed. Here are some other ways to translate this:

was to set in order the remaining matters (NET)

to do what still needed to be done (GW)

so that you could put in order the things that still needed doing (GNT)

set in order: This phrase means “organize” or “cause things to be the way they should be.”

what was unfinished: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what was unfinished is more literally “the left/remaining things.” There were some things that Paul thought should be done for the churches on Crete that had not yet been done. The churches needed to have proper leadership, false teachers needed to be corrected, and people needed to be taught proper doctrine and how Christians should behave. Paul had started this work and now asked Titus to continue it.

In your translation, avoid implying that someone was to blame for not finishing the task. Paul was not accusing Titus or anyone else of not finishing something.

He was just saying that there was more yet to do. It may be helpful to translate this as:

the things that still need doing

the remaining tasks/items

1:5c

and appoint elders in every town,

- In every town you should put elders in charge of each church,
- I asked you to choose men to lead the congregations in every town on Crete where there are believers.

and appoint elders in every town: This was a further reason why Paul had left Titus on Crete. Appointing elders was probably one of the things that had not yet been done. Paul wanted Titus to appoint leaders in all the local congregations.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

so that you could appoint church leaders in each town

appointing spiritual leaders in every city (GW)

appoint elders: Paul told Titus to appoint or “select” men and put them in charge of each local congregation. The text does not say how this happened. If possible, you should use a term or expression which does not specify how Titus was to appoint them.

Here is another way this could be translated:

put them in the seat/position of elder

elders: The word elders literally means “old men.” Here it refers to church leaders, men who helped to teach the other believers and who made decisions in the church.

1:5d

as I directed you.

- as I told you to do .
- Remember how I instructed you to do this.

as I directed you: Before Paul left Crete, he had given Titus instructions about choosing these elders. Now he reminded him of these previous instructions.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

as I told you before

Remember my instructions. (GNT)

Paul’s instructions included the things he went on to list in 1:6–9.

I: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as I has special emphasis. Paul used this pronoun to emphasize that he was saying these things because he had the authority of an apostle. If you use emphatic pronouns in your language, try to use one here.

Titus 1:6

Section 1:5–9: Paul instructs Titus to appoint elders in the churches

In this section Paul began the main content of his letter, which continues through 3:11. He made a general statement about what he wanted Titus to do and then talked about how to choose men to be the leaders in the local churches. This section, especially 1:6–8, is very similar to 1 Timothy 3:1–7. If you have already translated 1 Timothy, you should compare your work there with the list here in Titus. Both lists talk about the character and behavior of elders in the church.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paul writes to Timothy concerning the appointment of church leaders

Instructions on how to select men to be elders in the churches

Qualifications for church leaders

1:6–9

In these verses, Paul lists several qualities that elders should have. His purpose in listing these qualities was to tell Titus what kind of people he should choose to be church leaders. They should be godly men whom others respected.

Paul used the singular: “An elder...he...he....” But what Paul was saying was true for everyone who wanted to become an elder. If it is more natural in your language to use a plural, you could translate like this: “Men/People whom you choose to be elders should be.... They should be...” Once you have decided whether you should use singular or plural, be consistent throughout 1:6–9.

Here is an example of an English version that uses plural forms in these verses:

⁶they must have a good reputation and be faithful in marriage. Their children must be followers of the Lord and not have a reputation for being wild and disobedient.

⁷Church officials are in charge of God's work, and so they must also have a good reputation. They must not be bossy, quick-tempered, heavy drinkers, bullies, or dishonest in business. ⁸Instead, they must be friendly to strangers and enjoy doing good things. They must also be sensible, fair, pure, and self-controlled. ⁹They must stick to the true message they were taught, so their good teaching can help others and correct everyone who opposes it. (CEV)

1:6a

An elder must be blameless,

- A/The man you choose as an elder must be someone whom no one can accuse of any fault
- These elders must be people/men who behave in a completely good/upright way.

An elder must be blameless: The list of qualities for elders starts with a Greek clause which more literally says "if anyone is blameless." In Greek this sentence is not complete, but Paul meant "If someone is blameless, then you may appoint him as an elder."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It is necessary for an elder to be blameless.

Appoint as elders men like this: a man whom no one can rightly accuse of doing wrong. (SSA)

Appoint as elders only those who are blameless.

blameless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blameless means "without fault, beyond reproach." A church leader must be someone who has always behaved in a moral and honest way so that no one has a reason to accuse him of doing wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

without fault (GNT)

have a good reputation (GW)

not be guilty of doing wrong

1:6b

the husband of but one wife,

- and who is faithful in his marriage.
- They must each be faithful to their own wife.

the husband of but one wife: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the husband of but one wife is literally "of one woman/wife a man/husband." There are several ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means that a church leader must be faithful to his wife (no adultery). For example:

Faithful in marriage (CEV) (CEV, NLT, NIV)

1. It means that a church leader must not have more than one wife at a time (no polygamy). For example:

the husband of one wife (NET) (BSB, ESV, GW, GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, NET, RSV, REB, NJB, NIV84)

1. It means that a church leader must not be someone who has remarried after the death of his spouse or their divorce (no remarriage). For example:

married only once (NABRE) (NABRE, NRSV)

Option (1) is supported by many commentaries, although it is followed by only a few English versions. It is possible that Paul had both ideas (1) and (2) in mind, that is, that he thought of a man "of one woman" as one who did not take either a lover or a second wife but had intimate relations with only one woman. Option (3) is less likely. Paul approved of remarriage for widows (1 Corinthians 7:8-9) and did not indicate that he would have given different advice to widowers. In New Testament times it was not uncommon for a young woman to die in childbirth and many Christian men must have remarried. So in your translation, it is good to translate in as literal a way as possible and allow for both options (1) and (2).

This verse part is probably not teaching that an elder must be a married man, although it is assumed that this will normally be the case.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

faithful in marriage (CEV)

faithful to his wife (NLT)

Paul wanted the church leaders to live in such a way that no one would have any reason to criticize them or the church by saying that an elder was not faithful to his wife.

This phrase also occurs in 1 Timothy 3:2 and 1 Timothy 3:12.

1:6c

having children who are believers

- His children must believe in Jesus.
- Their children must be believers

having children who are believers: The Greek text is more literally “having faithful/believing children.” Paul directed that the children of each elder must believe in Jesus and follow him. In other words, someone whose children do not believe should not become an elder. Paul was probably not saying that people without children should not become elders.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and have children who are believers (GW)

His/Their children must be followers of the Lord.

1:6d

and who are not open to accusation of indiscretion or insubordination.

- They must behave well so that no one can accuse them of being wild or rebellious.
- and must not have a reputation for being out of control or for disobeying those in authority.

and who are not open to accusation of indiscretion or insubordination: This continues the description of the children of elders. They should not act in a way that would allow people to accuse them of indiscretion or insubordination.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and do not have the reputation of being wild or disobedient

His children shouldn't be known for having wild lifestyles or being rebellious. (GW)

not accused of indecent behavior or rebellion (NASB)

open to accusation of: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as open to accusation of means “can be

accused of,” that is, can be truly or rightfully accused of something.

indiscretion: The word that the BSB translates as indiscretion means “self-indulgent, unrestrained.” It refers to doing whatever you want and enjoying yourself in an uncontrolled way. This may include things like getting drunk, fighting, going to wild parties, or having sex outside of marriage.

Here is another way to translate this word:

living in a way that is not controlled

indecent behavior (NASB)

This word is also used in Ephesians 5:18 and 1 Peter 4:4 (in which cases the BSB translates it as “reckless indiscretion”).

insubordination: The Greek word that the BSB translates as insubordination describes someone who is unruly or disobedient. Here it refers to people who refuse to obey their parents or anybody else in authority.

Here is another way to translate this word:

rebellious against those in authority

rebellious

Titus 1:7

Section 1:5–9: Paul instructs Titus to appoint elders in the churches

In this section Paul began the main content of his letter, which continues through 3:11. He made a general statement about what he wanted Titus to do and then talked about how to choose men to be the leaders in the local churches. This section, especially 1:6–8, is very similar to 1 Timothy 3:1–7. If you have already translated 1 Timothy, you should compare your work there with the list here in Titus. Both lists talk about the character and behavior of elders in the church.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paul writes to Timothy concerning the appointment of church leaders

Instructions on how to select men to be elders in the churches

Qualifications for church leaders

1:7a

As God's steward, an overseer must be above reproach—

- Since a church leader is in charge of God's work, he must have no faults.
- God gives church leaders the job of caring for the believers. Therefore, people should not be able to accuse them of doing any wrong.

As God's steward, an overseer must be above reproach: The Greek is more literally "For an overseer/bishop must be blameless as a steward of God." God has given overseers the responsible position of steward, and so it is important that they be blameless.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

For since a church leader is in charge of God's work, he should be without fault. (GNT)

An overseer is God's servant who takes care of his work/people. So he must be without fault.

Because a bishop is a supervisor appointed by God, he must have a good reputation. (GW)

In some languages, it may be more natural to follow the Greek order. For example:

For the overseer must be blameless as one entrusted with God's work. (NET)

Since Paul was writing about overseers in general and not one particular overseer, in some languages it may be natural to use a plural form. For example:

God has given overseers the task of watching over his people. So they must be without blame.

overseer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as overseer is often translated as "bishop." Many scholars think that "elder" (1:5) and overseer are two words for the same church leaders. According to this interpretation, Paul was still talking about the kind of people whom Titus should choose to be elders.

God's steward: This phrase indicates that the overseer had the position of steward working for God. In New Testament times, a steward was an important servant who was responsible to manage his master's business, possessions, or household. A master often

gave his steward authority over other servants. And in the church, the work of the church leader is to look after the work and ministry of the church and to take care of God's people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a supervisor appointed by God (GW)

responsible for the welfare/wellbeing of God's people

must be above reproach: Paul was saying that it is necessary for church leaders to be above reproach. The phrase above reproach translates the same word that Paul used in 1:6a that the BSB translated as "blameless." You should translate it in the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

a church leader must be blameless

You should choose those who are blameless.

Choose blameless men.

1:7b–8

Here Paul began to describe in more detail how a church leader should behave. In 1:7b–d Paul listed five ways in which a church leader should not behave. Then in 1:8 Paul listed six ways in which a church leader should behave.

1:7b

not self-absorbed, not quick-tempered,

- Do not choose someone who is determined to get his way, or someone who easily loses his temper,
- They must not be men who demand their own way or get angry quickly.

not self-absorbed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-absorbed means "arrogant, bossy." Paul said that a church overseer is not to be like this. He must not insist on his own way as though he were a king or dictator or boss.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not arrogant (NET)

He must not be one who demands his own way.

They must not be bossy (CEV)

not quick-tempered: The Greek word that the BSB translates as quick-tempered means “quick to get angry.” The church leader must not be someone who becomes angry quickly or easily. He must keep his anger under control.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not become angry quickly

not hot tempered

He must not get angry easily. (NirV)

They must not be prone/inclined to anger.

1:7c

not given to drunkenness, not violent,

- drinks too much wine, likes to fight,
- They must not make a habit of getting drunk or getting into fights with other people.

not given to drunkenness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as given to drunkenness refers to someone who makes a habit of drinking a lot of alcohol so that he becomes drunk.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not a drunkard

not a heavy drinker (NJB)

He must not be someone who often gets drunk.

The same word is used in 1 Timothy 3:3a where the BSB translates it as “dependent on wine.” Try to translate it the same way in both places.

not violent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as violent means “striker, brawler.” This refers to a person who often fights with other people or who is rough with others in language or actions. It refers mainly to fighting physically, but it can include yelling and arguing, too. Paul wrote that church leaders must not be men who behaved like this.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

not fight a lot

He must not like to fight with others.

The same word is used in 1 Timothy 3:3b. Try to translate it the same way here.

1:7d

not greedy for money.

- or tries to get rich by cheating other people.
- And they must not be men who cheat other people to get money.

not greedy for money: There is an interpretation issue with the Greek word that the BSB translates as greedy for money. Scholars have interpreted it in two ways:

1. It refers to doing wrong things in order to become wealthy. For example:

use shameful ways to make money (GW) (NIV, CEV, NCV, GW, NABRE)

1. It refers to strongly desiring to become wealthy. For example:

greedy for money (NASB) (BSB, RSV/NRSV, ESV, GNT, NASB, REB, NET, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as do a majority of the commentaries.

The Greek word probably refers to someone who wants money so much that he would lie, cheat, or take bribes in order to get more money. This kind of person might use his position of authority in the church as a way to get money from other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this is phrase:

He must not be a person who will do anything to get money.

He must not try to get money by cheating people (NirV)

The same term is used in 1 Timothy 3:8.

Titus 1:8

Section 1:5–9: Paul instructs Titus to appoint elders in the churches

In this section Paul began the main content of his letter, which continues through 3:11. He made a general statement about what he wanted Titus to do and then talked about how to choose men to be the leaders

in the local churches. This section, especially 1:6–8, is very similar to 1 Timothy 3:1–7. If you have already translated 1 Timothy, you should compare your work there with the list here in Titus. Both lists talk about the character and behavior of elders in the church.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paul writes to Timothy concerning the appointment of church leaders

Instructions on how to select men to be elders in the churches

Qualifications for church leaders

1:8a

Instead, he must be hospitable,

- Instead, he must be someone who loves to welcome strangers/people
- Instead of being like that those you choose must be men who welcome people into their homes

Instead: This conjunction indicates a contrast. The contrast is between verse 7 and verse 8. In 1:7b–d, Paul gave five ways church leaders should not act. In verse 8 he lists six ways they should act. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction *Instead*.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Rather (NIV)

But (ESV)

In some languages it is necessary to begin verse 8 with a short sentence like:

No, they should not be like this. Instead...

he must be hospitable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *he must be hospitable* is more literally just “hospitable.” The BSB has supplied the verb phrase *he must be* in order to translate verse 8 as a separate sentence.

The Greek word meaning hospitable comes from root words meaning “friendly, loving” and “stranger, outsider.” A church leader must be a person who is happy to welcome people from outside his family into his home as guests.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He must be friendly to strangers

He must be ready to welcome guests

If you have been referring to the church leaders in the plural, continue to do so here. For example:

Overseers must be ready to welcome guests (NCV)

See also the notes on 1 Timothy 3:2d, where the same word hospitable is used. Translate it the same way in both verses.

1:8b

a lover of good,

- and loves to do what is right.
- and who delight in doing good to others.

a lover of good: This phrase indicates that a church leader must be someone who is happy to do what is right and good. Again, Paul was speaking of church leaders in general, and in some languages it may be more natural to use the plural.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and enjoy doing good things (CEV)

devoted to what is good (NET)

full of love for whatever is good

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a clause or sentence. For example:

He must love what is good. (NIRV)

Overseers must...love what is good. (NCV)

1:8c

self-controlled, upright,

- He should be serious, do what is just,
- They must act in a sensible way and behave fairly.

self-controlled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *self-controlled* describes a person who is sensible, thoughtful, or prudent. He is in control of himself and so is able to act wisely, calmly, and appropriately in every situation.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

able to control himself (SSA)

he/they must behave in a sensible manner

This word also occurs in 1 Timothy 3:2c. See how you translated it there. If it is possible and natural, translate it the same way here.

upright: The Greek word that the BSB translates as upright means “righteous” or “just.” A church leader must behave toward other people in a way that is fair and just.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

must live right (ERV)

he/they must do what is just

1:8d

holy, and disciplined.

- act in a pure manner, and control himself.
- They must be dedicated to God and able to control/rule their desires and actions.

holy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as holy means “pure” and “wholly devoted to God.” It describes something or someone as being separated to God, set apart for God’s use.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

His ways must be pure.

His heart must be dedicated to God.

For further discussion see “holy” in KBT.

disciplined: This word describes a person who can control his desires and actions. He does things in moderation and not to excess. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

he must control his own desires and actions

he must be able to control himself

Titus 1:9

Section 1:5–9: Paul instructs Titus to appoint elders in the churches

In this section Paul began the main content of his letter, which continues through 3:11. He made a general statement about what he wanted Titus to do and then talked about how to choose men to be the leaders in the local churches. This section, especially 1:6–8, is very similar to 1 Timothy 3:1–7. If you have already translated 1 Timothy, you should compare your work there with the list here in Titus. Both lists talk about the character and behavior of elders in the church.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Paul writes to Timothy concerning the appointment of church leaders

Instructions on how to select men to be elders in the churches

Qualifications for church leaders

1:9

In 1:6–8 Paul said that church leaders must behave in a way that pleases God. Now in 1:9 he wrote that church leaders must think and teach correctly about the gospel.

This is the last part of Paul’s list of requirements for church leaders. If it is natural in your language, you could begin 1:9 with a linking word such as “Finally.”

1:9a

He must hold firmly to the faithful word as it was taught,

- He must faithfully keep/support the true message about Jesus Christ that we^(dual/incl) taught him.
- They must firmly believe the gospel teachings that we can depend on that they were taught.

He must hold firmly to the faithful word: Many English versions begin this verse with the pronoun He. It refers to the people whom Titus was to appoint as elders. Paul has been talking about these people since 1:5b. If you use a pronoun here, you need to check that it is clear that these people are still being referred to. If it is not clear, you will need to use a noun like “an elder” (see NCV). In some languages it may be more natural to use a plural form.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He must hold firmly to the faithful message (NET)

He must be devoted to the trustworthy message (GW)

He must have a strong belief in the trustworthy message (NLT)

hold firmly: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as hold firmly means to believe strongly and persistently in something. It refers to holding something in one's mind rather than in one's physical body. Use the expression that is natural in your language for faithful belief in something.

the faithful word: This phrase refers to the gospel teachings about Jesus Christ. The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithful means "reliable" or "sure." It refers to something that is true and does not change. Paul was saying that the gospel is something that people can trust and depend on.

The phrase faithful word also occurs in 3:8, 1 Timothy 1:15, 1 Timothy 4:9; 2 Timothy 2:11.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the teachings that are true

the good news that does not change

the true message (CEV)

as it was taught: Paul said that elders should strongly believe the gospel as it was taught. A literal English translation of the Greek is "according to the teaching." Paul is saying that the church leaders must firmly believe the same teaching about Jesus Christ that he and the other apostles taught. They must not change those teachings.

This clause is passive. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

he was taught (NLT)

- Use an active verb. The subject could be Paul and the other apostles (exclusive of Titus), or Paul and his fellow workers (inclusive of Titus). For example:

as we^(excl) apostles taught it to you^(sing)

just as we^(incl) taught it to him/them

1:9b

so that he can encourage others by sound teaching

- In that way he will be able to help people follow correct teaching
- Then they will be able to teach other people what is correct. In this way they can encourage them to follow this teaching.

so that he can encourage others by sound teaching:

The conjunction so that here introduces Paul's purposes in giving his instruction in 1:9a. This verse part gives the first purpose. If it is natural to do so in your language, you could begin a new sentence here. For example:

He must do this so that he can encourage others by teaching doctrine that is true.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this purpose clause as a clause that indicates the expected result. For example:

Then he can use these accurate teachings to encourage people. (GW)

Then he will be able to encourage others with wholesome teaching. (NLT)

In this way he will be able to encourage others with the true teaching (GNT)

he can encourage others: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as encourage does not have an explicit object. The BSB has supplied the object others. In some languages it may be natural to supply a different object. For example:

overseers can help people (NCV)

by sound teaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sound means "healthy, wholesome." Here it is used figuratively to describe a body of teaching that is true or correct. This kind of teaching is spiritually health-giving. It helps believers to become healthy in their minds and spirits and to think and act in a way that pleases God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

with the true teaching (GNT)

with wholesome teaching (NCV)

teaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as teaching means “teaching/instruction.” Here it refers to the true teaching about Jesus.

1:9c

and refute those who contradict it.

- and show its opponents/enemies that they are wrong.
- And also, when they speak to people who reject this teaching, they will be able to convince them of their error.

and refute those who contradict it: This is another purpose for Paul’s instruction that an elder should firmly believe the trustworthy message about Jesus. There will be people who contradict the message and refuse to believe it. An elder is to firmly believe the gospel so that he can refute those people. To refute them means to show them that they are wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and also to show the error of those who are opposed to it (GNT)

and show those who oppose it where they are wrong (NLT)

and show those who are against the true teaching that they are wrong

Titus 1:10

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:10a

For many are rebellious

- ¶ For many people oppose/reject the authority of their leaders

- ¶ Choose as church leaders men like this, because many people in the churches/congregations are fighting/arguing with their leaders.

For: This word introduces a reason for Paul’s instructions about choosing church leaders. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Because

Do this/that because

many are rebellious: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rebellious describes people who reject and oppose leaders and authority figures. Paul said that there were many such people. The context shows that he was talking about people in the congregations on the island of Crete.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

many people there are rebellious

many people reject/oppose their leaders

There are many who don’t respect authority (CEV)

1:10b

and full of empty talk and deception,

- and talk a lot of empty words and lies.
- They are talking nonsense and leading other believers astray.

and full of empty talk and deception: The Greek words that the BSB translates as full of empty talk and deception are more literally “empty talkers and deceivers” (see the NASB). Paul was describing people who regularly say things that are not true or helpful and try to make others believe their lies.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

talk about worthless things and lead others into the wrong way (NCV)

who talk nonsense and try to make others believe it (NJB)

full of...deception: The Greek word that the BSB translates as full of...deception is literally “deceivers.” It indicates that these people tried to convince others that their falsehoods were true. They wanted people

to believe that their teaching was true, even though it was not.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

and deceive others (GNT)

they are liars

1:10c

especially those of the circumcision,

- This is especially true of the group/circle that says that everyone must be circumcised.
- I am mainly referring to those who demand/require that all believing men receive/undergo circumcision.

especially: This word here indicates that Paul was thinking of one group in particular. One group of people was very rebellious, talked nonsense, and deceived other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

This is especially true of (CEV)

in particular

But the worst of those who do this are
Otomi Back Translation on TW

The group that does this/that the most is

those of the circumcision: This phrase refers to Jews who claimed to be Christians but wanted all Christians to follow the Jewish laws. In particular, they wanted all Christian men to be circumcised.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the group that insists that all men be circumcised

those people who teach that believing men must follow the Jewish laws and have someone circumcise them

Titus 1:11

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called

them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:11a

who must be silenced.

- These/Those people must be stopped from saying those things.
- Someone/You^(sing) must cause these/those people to stop demanding/requiring this.

who must be silenced: The Greek is more literally “it is necessary to put something over their mouths.” It indicates that someone should stop or prevent these rebellious people from talking rebellion, nonsense, and lies (1:10a–b). Somebody, probably Titus, must make them stop this kind of talk. In your translation, avoid implying that these people must stop talking completely.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

you must make them be quiet (CEV)

It is necessary to stop their talk (GNT)

It is necessary that they be stopped from saying those things

In the Greek text, the fact that the following clauses give the reason for Paul’s command in 1:11a is implicit. Some translations supply a conjunction in order to introduce the reason why someone should silence the rebellious people. You also may want to do this to make this relationship explicit if that is natural in your language. For example:

They must be silenced because for the sake of dishonest gain, they are disrupting whole households

1:11b

For the sake of dishonorable gain,

- They only teach those things so that they can get money by their lies,
- Their only purpose is to make a profit, and they do it in a shameful way!

For the sake of dishonorable gain: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as dishonorable gain is more literally “shameful gain.” It refers to obtaining money by shameful means, that is, dishonest means. These people were trying to make money by teaching lies.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

For shameful gain

In order to make a profit by lying

This is the shameful way they make money. (CEV)

For the sake of: This phrase means “For the purpose of.”

1:11c

they undermine entire households

- and they are causing entire families to be troubled/distressed
- For they are damaging/destroying the peace/well-being of entire families.

they undermine entire households: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they undermine means that the rebellious people were causing entire families to be upset and distressed. They were distressed because the teachings of these rebellious people conflicted with the teachings of the gospel of Jesus.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they are causing great turmoil in whole households

they are upsetting whole families (NASB)

they are breaking the peace of entire families

entire households: The Greek word that the BSB translates as households refers to people living in one house. In Paul’s time this usually consisted of one extended family and their servants.

1:11d

and teach things they should not.

- by teaching what they should not teach.
- This is the result of giving such false/wrong teaching/instruction.

and teach things they should not: This phrase introduces the way in which these rebellious people disrupted whole households. They did so by teaching

what was false. You may be able to make this clear by saying:

They do this by teaching what they should not teach

in that they teach things that they should not

General Comment on 1:11c-d d-b

In some languages it may be natural to order the information in 1:11b-d as it is in Greek. The Greek is more literally, “who overturn entire households, teaching what they should not for the sake of dishonest gain.” “Dishonest gain” was the purpose of the false teachers in teaching “things they should not.”

Here are some other ways to translate these Greek words:

because they are ruining whole families by teaching what they shouldn’t teach. This is the shameful way they make money. (GW)

They undermine entire households for the sake of dishonest gain by teaching things that they must not teach.

because they mislead whole families by teaching for dishonest gain what ought not to be taught. (NET)

Titus 1:12

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:12a

As one of their own prophets has said,

- One of their own pagan prophets has said,
- Long ago, one of the spokesmen of the gods whom the people of Crete worship said,

As one of their own prophets has said: The words has said here indicate that this prophet spoke the words of 1:12b–d some time before Paul wrote this letter to Titus. He probably spoke and wrote this several hundred years beforehand. 1:12 The writer Callimachus, who lived three centuries before Christ, wrote in his Hymn to Zeus (line 8) that “Cretans are always liars.” He was quoting the Cretan poet Epimenides who lived three centuries earlier, who wrote, “The Cretans, always liars, evil beasts, idle bellies” in his poem Cretica. Use an appropriate way to indicate that. For example:

One of Crete’s own prophets said this long ago

one of their own prophets: This phrase indicates that this man was from, or lived in, the island of Crete.

prophets: Here the word prophets refers to people who spoke on behalf of one of the gods of Crete. The usual meaning of prophets in the New Testament refers to people who speak on behalf of God. Your translation should not indicate or imply that this person spoke on behalf of God. You may need to make it explicit that Paul was referring to spokesmen of the idols whom the people of Crete worshiped. For example:

spokesmen of their gods

pagan prophets

1:12b

“Cretans are always liars,

- ““The/Our/We people of Crete always lie/deceive,
- “The people who live in Crete are certainly liars.

Cretans are always liars: This clause is an exaggeration. It means that the people who lived in Crete had the habit of telling lies.

The prophet who was speaking was himself a Cretan. But he was not saying that he was telling a lie. So in some languages it may be necessary to remove the exaggeration in order to convey the correct meaning. For example:

Cretans are habitual liars

We Cretans certainly tell many lies

Cretans: This word means “the people of Crete.”

1:12c

evil beasts,

- and are like wicked wild animals,
- They are wicked and wild.

evil beasts: The phrase “Cretans are” is implied from 1:12b. In some languages it is more natural to make this a clause. For example:

and they are evil brutes

This phrase compares Cretans to wild animals who do bad things. This is a figure of speech, a metaphor. It means that they acted without self-control or good morals. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keeping the metaphor. For example:

they are wicked wild animals

- Using a simile. For example:

they are like wicked wild animals

- Explaining the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

they are wicked and unrestrained, like wild animals

- Translate only the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

they are wicked and wild people If you do this, you may then want to give a literal translation of the Greek in a footnote. Here is an example footnote:

Literally, “wicked wild animals.”

Translate this figure of speech in the way that is most natural in your language and allows your readers to understand the correct meaning.

1:12d

lazy gluttons.”

- lazy and greedy.”
- They love to lie around and eat.”

lazy gluttons: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as lazy gluttons is more literally “lazy/idle stomachs.” It refers to people who are focused on

eating and drinking rather than working. Their lives are centered around eating and drinking.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

lazy people who are always eating

too lazy to work but not too lazy to eat

They are lazy but love to eat.

They eat/consume a lot but do not work.

This phrase concludes the quotation from the Cretan prophet.

Titus 1:13

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:13a

This testimony is true.

- That saying is true.
- This saying/proverb is still relevant to them.

This testimony is true: Paul himself begins speaking here again. These words are not from the Cretan prophet. In some languages this may be made clear by the ending of 1:12d. In some languages this must be made clear here. For example:

And I, Paul, say that this saying is true

What the prophet said about the Cretans is true.

1:13b

Therefore rebuke them sternly,

- Therefore, rebuke^(sing) them strongly
- So you must rebuke those who are fighting/arguing with their leaders.

Therefore rebuke them sternly: The phrase rebuke them sternly means to tell them very strongly that they are wrong. The Greek tense indicates an ongoing action. For example:

Therefore, keep/continue rebuking them strongly

them: This word probably refers to the rebellious people. Someone rebukes someone else because the other person is doing something bad. The rebellious people are most clearly doing something bad. The saying of the Cretan prophet is only an explanation of why these rebellious people are that way. It is not introducing all the people of Crete as the subject of Paul's instructions. In some languages a literal translation will be clear enough. In some languages explaining who this group is will be helpful. For example:

those rebellious people

1:13c

so that they will be sound in the faith

- so that their faith will be correct/right
- My purpose/goal is that they will believe strongly/firmly in the true faith.

so that they will be sound in the faith: This is a purpose clause. The phrase so that introduces Paul's first purpose in telling Titus to rebuke rebellious people. He wanted Titus to help them become strong in the true faith. For example:

so that they may become sound in the faith (NRSV)

in order that they may believe accurately

so that they continue to have faith that is alive and well (GW)

to make them strong in the faith (NLT)

they will be sound in the faith: Here the word sound means "healthy" or "free of errors." See how you translated the word sound in 1:9.

in the faith: The phrase the faith here refers to the content of the Christian religion as a whole. This includes its doctrines about Jesus Christ and the gospel as well as its teachings about how Christians should behave.

Titus 1:14

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:14a

and will pay no attention to Jewish myths

- and they will stop thinking about Jewish myths/fables/stories
- I want them to ignore the false narratives that the Jewish leaders have handed/passed down

and will pay no attention to Jewish myths: This is the second purpose for rebuking the rebellious Cretan people. Paul wanted Titus to rebuke the rebellious believers so that they would stop paying attention to Jewish myths.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they will stop thinking about Jewish myths

They shouldn't pay attention to Jewish myths (GW)

The word "they" is implied from 1:13c.

Jewish myths: A "myth" is a fictional story that people pass down from one generation to another. Often in these stories people do things that normal people cannot do. These myths were Jewish probably because Jews wrote them about Jews.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

fantasy/imaginary stories that the Jews wrote

Jewish stories that did not really happen

1:14b

or to the commands of men who have rejected the truth.

- or about commands that men/people have given/made. These are men/people who reject the truth!
- and to the worldly rules made by people who reject God's truth.

or to the commands of men who have rejected the truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the commands of men is literally "the human commands." Paul was saying that ordinary people spoke or wrote these commands. They did not come from God. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

or to commands that people wrote/invented themselves

or to human rules

or commands given by people who are always rejecting the truth (GW)

who have rejected the truth: Here the word truth refers to God's truth, God's true message. In some languages it may be natural to translate these words as a separate sentence. For example:

Those things are the ideas of people who refuse to obey God's true message. (EASY)

Those commands/rules are made up by people who reject the true word/message from God.

Titus 1:15

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:15a

To the pure, all things are pure;

- Everything that God has made is pure to/for people who are pure in their hearts/insides.

- For the people who are clean before God, all things in God's creation are clean.

To the pure, all things are pure: In this verse part Paul used the word pure in two ways. First it refers to people who are morally and spiritually pure. Then in the second occurrence it refers to objects that are ritually pure and acceptable for use by God's people.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

If someone is clean and good inside, everything is clean and good for them to enjoy. (EASY)

Everything is pure for someone whose heart is pure. (CEV)

All things are ritually clean to those who are clean/pure in heart.

To the pure: The phrase the pure refers to people who are spiritually and morally clean because they have been cleansed by God through their faith in Jesus. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

To people who are pure (NIRV)

To those who are pure/clean in their heart/spirit

all things are pure: This clause indicates that all things that God has made are good and there is nothing inherently wrong in them. Paul was probably thinking of Jesus' teaching that his disciples need not obey the Jewish food laws about clean and unclean foods. See Mark 7:19c and Romans 14:20b. See also 1 Timothy 4:3-4. Paul was not saying that all actions are pure and right. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

all created things/objects are clean

all food items are ritually pure

1:15b

but to the defiled and unbelieving, nothing is pure.

- But nothing is pure to corrupt and unbelieving people.
- But for those people who have turned to evil and do not believe the truth/gospel, nothing is truly clean.

but to the defiled and unbelieving: The phrase the defiled refers to people who are not pure, people who

have bad morals. It is the same group of people as those who are unbelieving. Here are some other ways to translate these words:

but to those who are corrupt and unbelieving (NET)

to corrupt unbelievers (GW)

but...to those who are defiled and unbelieving (GNT)

and unbelieving: This implies that these are people who do not believe in Jesus and the gospel.

nothing is pure: This is the opposite of "all things are pure" in 1:15a. Paul was probably implying that these people defiled everything they touched. Because they were not pure in heart, they could offer nothing that was acceptable to God.

1:15c

Indeed, both their minds and their consciences are defiled.

- Indeed, the way they think and the way they judge good from evil are both warped/twisted.
- For their minds have turned to evil, and their way to decide right and wrong is bad.

Indeed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Indeed here introduces a stronger additional statement. Here are some other ways to translate this:

In fact

Truly

both their minds and their consciences are defiled:

This clause explains "the defiled" in 1:15b. The meaning of these people being defiled is emphasized because it is repeated here.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

their minds and their sense of what is right and wrong are twisted (NIRV)

Both their minds and their consciences have been ruined. (NCV)

their minds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as minds refers to a person's thinking, intellect, or understanding.

consciences: The Greek word that the BSB translates as consciences refers to the aspect of a person's thinking that causes him to feel ashamed or guilty when he does something wrong. It refers to how a person judges or evaluates his own deeds and behavior, approving or disapproving what he has done.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

their assessment/evaluation of their deeds

their sense of what is right and wrong (NIRV)

Titus 1:16

Section 1:10–16: Paul told Titus to rebuke rebellious people

In this section Paul warned Titus about those in Crete who were opposing correct teaching. They were deceiving believers and ruining their faith. Paul called them liars. They claimed to know God but in reality they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this heading:

Correct Whoever Teaches What Is Wrong (GW)

You^(sing) must rebuke those who are rebellious

1:16a

They profess to know God,

- They tell people that they know God,
- They say to people, "We^(excl) know God."

They profess to know God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as They profess means to say that something is true, whether it is true or is not true. It implies that the person speaking wants his listeners to believe what he said. Here, these people did not know God but said that they knew God. They wanted their listeners to believe that they knew God.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They told people that they knew God

They say that they know God

They declare, "We^(excl) know God."

They: This pronoun refers to the people described in 1:15b–c.

1:16b

but by their actions they deny Him.

- but, by what they do, they show that they reject him.
- But their deeds show that they do not love him.

but by their actions they deny Him: These people were doing things that showed that they did not know God or believe in him. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

but they deny that they know him by what they do

However, by the way they act they show that to be a lie.

The Greek and the BSB have placed the phrase by their actions in the front of the clause to emphasize it. Some languages cannot emphasize it in that way. Try to emphasize this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

1:16c

They are detestable, disobedient,

- They are awful/abhorrent people who do not obey God,
- They deserve to be rejected. They refuse to obey God.

They are detestable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as detestable means "horrible/awful/disgusting." God is disgusted with their deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They are disgusting

They are horrible people.

disobedient: This word here indicates that these people did not obey God. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they always disobey

they never obey God

1:16d

and unfit for any good deed.

- and are not fit/qualified to do any good thing.
- They are useless/worthless for any good task/deed.

and unfit for any good deed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unfit refers to failing a test. Here the test is about doing good. These people failed that

test, so they are not qualified to do good. If they tried to do good, they would fail.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and they are not able to do anything good

and they are not competent to do any good thing

Titus 2:1

Section 2:1-15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

2:1

But as for you, speak the things that are consistent with sound doctrine.

- ¶ But as for you^(sing), teach those things that are consistent with the true teaching about Jesus Christ.
- ¶ But you Titus must instruct the believers to behave in a way that agrees with wholesome teaching.

But as for you, speak the things that are consistent with sound doctrine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here indicates contrast. In 1:10-16 Paul had written about the behavior of the false teachers. Here Paul began to instruct Titus on how he should teach. He should teach differently from the false teachers.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

You, however, must teach what is appropriate to sound doctrine. (NIV)

For your part, what you say must be in keeping with sound doctrine. (REB)

But you must teach what agrees with sound doctrine. (GNT)

But as for you: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as you is singular and refers to Titus. In Greek the presence of a separate pronoun like this usually expressed emphasis. Consider how you might translate this to show emphasis. Since this is the start of a

new chapter and section it might be helpful to include Titus' name.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

But you (NCV)

As for you, Titus (NLT)

speak: In Greek this is a command in the present tense. It indicates that Titus should continue to speak or communicate in a certain way. Because this verb is followed by instructions for how other people should behave, several English versions translate it as "teach."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

teach (NIV)

tell (GW)

communicate (NET)

the things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the things is an indefinite word that here refers in general to teachings about the behaviors Paul wanted Titus to encourage.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

the teachings

those matters

that are consistent with: The Greek word that the BSB translates as are consistent with means "agrees with" or "are in accord with." Titus' teachings should not be just his own ideas but should be consistent with true doctrine, the doctrine that Paul had taught him.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

agrees with (GNT)

is in accord with (NIV)

sound doctrine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sound means "healthy, wholesome." Here it is used figuratively to describe a body of teaching that is true or correct. This kind of teaching is spiritually health-giving. It helps believers to be strong in their

faith and to behave in a way that is consistent with their faith.

The same Greek phrase translated here as sound doctrine occurs also in 1:9 where the BSB translated it as “sound teaching.” Try to translate it the same way in both places.

doctrine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as doctrine is more literally “teaching/instruction.” Here it refers to the true teaching about Jesus.

Titus 2:2

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

2:2a

Older men are to be temperate, dignified, self-controlled,

- You must teach the older men to be sober/serious, deserving of respect, and self-controlled.
- Teach the older men that they must think clearly. They should be virtuous and sensible men.

Older men are to be temperate, dignified, self-controlled: There is no verb in Greek at the beginning of this verse, but many English versions supply a verb. For example:

Teach

Instruct (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

Older men are to be temperate, dignified, sensible (NASB)

The older men should be sober, dignified, and temperate (REB)

Instruct the older men to be sober, sensible, and self-controlled (GNT)

Older men: The Greek word refers in general to male believers who were older than 40 or 50. It is similar to, but not the same as, the word used for elders of the church.

temperate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temperate means “restrained” or “moderate.” It usually refers to not drinking too much alcohol but can also have the wider meaning of being restrained and moderate in conduct and behavior. See how you translated the same word at 1 Timothy 3.2c.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sober (GNT)

sober-minded (ESV)

calm

dignified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dignified describes someone who is respected by others and deserves to be so respected. This kind of respect was associated with the behavior of a serious and mature person.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

worthy of respect (NIV)

respectable

self-controlled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-controlled describes someone who is thoughtful and deliberate in his actions rather than impulsive. See how you translated it in 1:8c and translate it the same way in both places. For example:

They must control themselves. (NIRV)

able to control themselves

2:2b

and sound in faith, love, and perseverance.

- They must firmly believe in God, sincerely love other people, and faithfully follow Jesus Christ.
- Their trust in God and their love for others should be solid. They should not turn back/away from the Lord during difficult times.

and sound in faith, love, and perseverance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sound is literally

“healthy,” that is, health-giving or wholesome. Here it describes a man as being solid and firm in the way he trusts God, loves others, and endures hardship. It is the same word used in 2:1 to describe correct doctrine. If possible, translate it the same in both places.

The three phrases in faith, love, and perseverance list three areas in which the older men should be solid and firm. The word *and* connects the areas of behavior (faith, love, and perseverance) to the word *sound*. Consider how best to indicate this in your language. For example:

sound in faith, sound in love, sound in endurance

strong in faith, in love, and in patience (NCV)

Their faith, love, and patience must never fail. (CEV)

They must have sound faith and be filled with love and patience. (NLT)

in faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faith here refers to trust in God, trust that comes from Christian belief. The older men should trust in God completely for everything they need.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the way they trust God

in their trust in God

love: The Greek word that the BSB translates as love here refers to the affection and warm regard that one person shows to another person. The older men should be healthy in the way they show love to others. They should be selfless in service to other people.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in the way they love other people

and perseverance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perseverance refers to the ability to not give up in the face of difficulty. Paul wanted the older men to endure or bear hardship. They should be patient and not quit when they met difficulties.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and in the way they bear up during difficult times

and in patience

General Comment on 2:2a-b

These verse parts include four items in a list (“temperate, worthy of respect, self-controlled, sound”). The BSB follows English style by separating the first three items with a comma and supplying the word “and” between the last two. Each of the items describes a type of behavior that the older men should follow. The verb “to be” is therefore implied for each of them. Follow your language style for constructing such a list.

The BSB has translated 2:2a-b as one clause. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this verse as two or more clauses or sentences, with more than one imperative verb. For example:

^{2a}Tell older men to be sober. Tell them to be men of good character, to use good judgment, ^{2b}and to be well-grounded in faith, love, and endurance. (GW)

^{2a}Teach the older men to exercise self-control, to be worthy of respect, and to live wisely. ^{2b}They must have sound faith and be filled with love and patience. (NLT)

Titus 2:3

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

2:3a

Older women, likewise, are to be reverent in their behavior,

- In a similar way, you^(sing) must teach the older women to live a holy life.
- Teach the older women that in the same way they should live lives dedicated to God.

Older women, likewise, are to be reverent in their behavior:

The BSB has supplied the verb *are* and the verb *to be*. Here are some other ways to translate this:

instruct the older women to behave as women should who live a holy life (GNT)

Tell older women to live their lives in a way that shows they are dedicated to God. (GW)

Older women: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Older women is used only here in the New Testament. The context suggests that it refers to women who were of a similar age to the men mentioned in 2:2, women in their forties or fifties or older.

likewise: This word indicates that Paul's next comments are similar to what he has just said. The older women should act in similar ways to the older men. Another way to translate this is:

In the same way

reverent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as reverent refers to behavior appropriate for a holy person, that is, someone who is dedicated to God.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase:

exhibit behavior fitting for those who are holy (NET)

to live their lives in a way that shows they are dedicated to God (GW)

to show their dedication to God

to behave as holy women should

in their behavior: The phrase refers generally to the way that they live, particularly the way they speak and look. The older women should act in ways that other people could see that they were dedicated to God.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

in the way they live (NIV)

in all that they do

2:3b

not slanderers or addicted to much wine,

- Teach/Tell them not to gossip nor to drink a lot of wine.

- They should not say bad things about others or allow a desire for alcohol to control them.

not slanderers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slanderers refers to people who accuse others of bad behavior. Here it refers to gossips, people who tell bad stories about others.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

not speaking against others (NCV)

not to be gossips (GW)

This behavior, and the one that follows, is something the older women should not do. In some languages it might be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

They should not be slanderers

Tell them not to be gossips (GW)

or addicted to much wine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as addicted is more literally “enslaved.” It refers to a person who is completely controlled by something or someone else. It is the second behavior the older women should not follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

or enslaved to too much wine (NCV)

not slaves to excessive drinking (NET)

and not controlled by alcohol

much wine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wine refers to a fermented alcoholic drink. It was a very common everyday drink in cultures of that time and place. Usually water was added to make it less intoxicating. The word much refers to drinking an excess of wine. Paul was not saying that the older women should not drink any wine at all.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

too much wine (NCV)

excessive drinking (NET)

2:3c but teachers of good.

- They should teach others things that are good/right.
- Tell them to teach good things

but teachers of good: In Greek this is a single word meaning “good teacher.” The BSB has supplied the word *but* to indicate a contrast with what the women should not do. However, most English versions connect this word to the positive instructions which follow in 2:4–5. If you connect it to what follows, it may not be necessary to supply a conjunction indicating contrast.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They must be teachers of right behavior (NJB)

They must teach what is proper (CEV)

Titus 2:4

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

2:4a

In this way they can train the young women

- In this way they will be able to teach/show the younger women how to behave.
- so they will give/set a good example for the younger women.

In this way: The Greek word that the BSB translates *In this way* indicates the purpose for doing something. Here it connects the idea of training younger women (2:4a) as the purpose for the older women teaching what is good (2:3c).

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

so that (NASB)

and so (REB)

they can train: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *train* means “encourage” or “advise.” The

older women should show the younger women how to behave through their own good conduct and advice.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they may encourage (NRSV)

they can show (the younger women) how

the young women: This is a general term referring to women old enough to be married but young enough to still have a husband and children to care for.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

young married women

2:4b

to love their husbands and children,

- They will be able to teach them how to act with love toward their husbands and children,
- They can show them how to behave in a loving way to their husbands and children,

to love their husbands and children: The Greek text is more literally “to be lovers of their husbands, lovers of their children.” These two ideas represent the mark of a good wife in both Greek and Jewish cultures. They describe a deep affection for family and a commitment to meeting their needs.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to take loving care of their husbands and children

to be loving wives and mothers (REB)

Titus 2:5

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

2:5a

to be self-controlled, pure,

- how to act wisely and be morally pure,
- how to be sensible and virtuous women,

to be self-controlled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-controlled refers to someone who is thoughtful about how they act, is not impulsive and avoids extremes. See how you translated it in 1:8c and 2:2a. Try to translate it in the same way in all three places.

pure: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pure means “ritually clean, free from contamination.” In this context it means moral purity, especially sexual purity. Paul was describing wives and mothers, so in this context it does not refer to celibacy (no sexual activity) but to faithfulness in marriage. It describes virtuous wives, that is, women who refrain from all sexual activity outside of their marriage.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

morally pure (GW)

chaste (NABRE)

virtuous women

2:5b

managers of their households, kind,

- taking care of their households, being kind to others,
- good homemakers, kind,

managers of their households: The Greek word that the BSB translates as managers of their households describes a woman who works hard at home and manages the household well. She takes care of the needs of her family and fulfills all her responsibilities in her home.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to be homemakers (GW)

good managers of their household (NRSV)

fulfilling their duties at home (NET)

kind: The Greek word that the BSB translates as kind can also be translated as “good.” There are two ways to understand this word in this context:

1. It refers to a separate quality, that of goodness in the sense of kindness. For example: to be kind (GW) (BSB, NIV, NET, ESV, NASB, NRSV, NJB, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV, GW, KJV)

2. It modifies the preceding quality in the list. For example: to be good housewives (GNT) (GNT, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as do the great majority of English versions.

2:5c

and submissive to their own husbands,

- and accepting/respectful of the authority of their husbands.
- and wives who listen to their husbands.

submissive to their own husbands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as submissive to describes someone who accepts the authority of someone else and takes a position subordinate to (under) that person. In the context of a marriage relationship, it can be understood as an attitude of respect, cooperation, and a willingness to serve. Try to use an expression that is natural in your language for an admirable attitude in married women.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to be subject to their husbands (NIV)

respecting the authority of their husbands (REB)

accepting the authority/leadership of their husbands

to place themselves under their husbands' authority (GW)

their own husbands: The women were not to be subject to all men but only to their own husbands in their own families.

2:5d

so that the word of God will not be discredited.

- Then people will not speak evil of God's message.
- They should behave like this so that no unbelievers will speak untrue things about the message that God gave us.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that here introduces a purpose clause. Paul gives his purpose in saying what he had just said about how younger women should behave. Paul's purpose in giving these instructions was that no one would be able to speak evil of God's gospel message.

the word of God will not be discredited: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be discredited means “to speak evil of.” If believing women did not behave

in the way Paul described, people would likely blame their Christian faith and say bad things about the gospel message.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

no one will malign the word of God (NIV)

no one can speak evil of God's word (GW)

no one can say insulting things about God's message (CEV)

the word of God: This phrase refers to the message that God gave Paul to preach and teach to the nations.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the message of God (NET)

the teaching that God gave us

Titus 2:6

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

2:6

In the same way, urge the younger men to be self-controlled.

- ¶ In a similar way, urge the young men to act wisely.
- ¶ In a similar way, tell the young men that they should behave in a sensible way.

In the same way: This phrase indicates that Paul's next comments are similar to what he just said. In Greek it is the same word that the BSB translates as "likewise" in 2:3.

Here are some other ways to translate it:

Likewise (NRSV)

Similarly (NIV)

urge the younger men to be self-controlled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as urge means to convince someone to think or behave in a particular way. See how you translated it in 1:9 and translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

urge the young men to be sensible (NASB)

urge the younger men to control themselves (RSV)

Encourage young men to use good judgment (GW)

the younger men: This phrase probably refers to men between 20 and 40 years old.

to be self-controlled: This Greek word refers to someone who is thoughtful about how he behaves, is not impulsive and avoids extremes. See how you translated it in 1:8, 2:2 and 2:5 and translate it the same in all four places.

Titus 2:7

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

2:7a

In everything,

- In everything that you^(sing) do
- Always/Continually

In everything: There are two ways to understand the phrase that the BSB translates as In everything:

1. It belongs with the instruction that follows, that Titus set a good example. For example: in all things show yourself to be an example (NASB) (BSB, NIV, RSV/NRSV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NCV, GW, NET, ESV, NABRE)
2. It belongs with the instruction in 2:6 that young men be "self-controlled." For example:

⁶Similarly, urge younger men to be moderate in everything that they do, ⁷and you yourself set

an example of good works (NJB) (CEV, REB, NJB, NRSVUE)

Either interpretation is acceptable and has scholarly support.^{2:7} For example, Mounce says that *σωφρονεῖν*, “to be self-controlled,” is such an important, all-encompassing term in the PE that *περι πάντα*, “in all things,” reads naturally with it (WBC, 412). However, the UBS Handbook and most translations take it to agree with what follows. You may wish to follow the interpretation in the major language version in your area.

2:7b

show yourself to be an example by doing good works.

- be an example for them by doing good deeds.
- do what is right, so that the young men can imitate you.

show yourself to be an example: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as show yourself to be an example is more literally “showing yourself as an example.” Paul wanted Titus to act in a good way so that he could be a model for the other young men to follow.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

set them an example (NIV)

act as a model

by doing good works: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates by doing good works is more literally “of good works.” It refers to actions that please God and help other people.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

of good works (ESV)

of good behavior (GNT)

2:7c

In your teaching show integrity, dignity,

- You must teach with right motives and in a way worthy of respect.
- When you teach other believers, do so sincerely and in a serious/sensible/thoughtful way.

In your teaching: The Greek word that the BSB translates as teaching here probably refers both to the actual work of teaching and to its content.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase as a dependent clause. It may also be necessary to supply an object and indicate whom Titus was to teach. For example:

When you are teaching (NJB)

When you teach the believers (EASY)

show integrity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as integrity means “soundness” or “without corruption.” Titus should teach things that he knew to be true, because he knew them to be true. He should not say things for selfish reasons or say what he did not really believe.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

do it with honesty (NCV)

be sincere (CEV)

dignity: This Greek word is similar to the one in 2:2b that the BSB translated as “dignified.” Both Titus’ behavior while teaching and the content of what he taught should not be silly or lightweight. He should teach in a way that was worthy of respect.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

seriousness (NIV)

gravity (NRSV)

General Comment on 2:7c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the phrases in this verse part. For example:

Be sincere and serious when you teach. (CEV)

Titus 2:8

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

2:8a
and wholesome speech that is above reproach,

- The things you teach/say must always be whole-some/true and above reproach/criticism.
- Teach what is true and cannot be criticized,

wholesome speech: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wholesome means “healthy” or “correct.” It is related to the words in 2:1 and 2:2b that are translated “sound” by the BSB. Here it describes the Greek word that the BSB translates as speech, which means “word” or “message.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sound words (GNT)

a sound message (NET)

that is above reproach: The Greek word that the BSB translates as above reproach often describes someone who is accused of a crime but is innocent. Titus should speak what is true so that any criticism someone might make of his teaching will have no basis.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

that cannot be condemned (NIV)

that no one can criticize (CEV)

2:8b
so that anyone who opposes us will be ashamed,

- Teach like this so that anyone who opposes you may be ashamed
- so that your enemies will feel ashamed.

so that anyone who opposes us will be ashamed: This is a purpose clause. It indicates Paul’s purpose in telling Titus to teach in a serious and sincere way.

anyone who opposes us: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as anyone who opposes us is more literally, “the opponent.” Paul probably did not have any one person in mind, but was referring in general to anyone who opposed Titus during his time of ministry on Crete. You may translate it using either a singular or plural form, whichever is most natural in your language. For example:

any opponent (NRSV)

your enemies (GNT)

us: This word is not in the Greek. Some versions add it or the word “you” in order to have an object for the verb “oppose.” If it is more natural in your language to say who “the opponent” is opposing, you may add either “us” to refer to Paul, Titus, and others who are working to promote the gospel message, or “you” or “your” to refer to Titus. For example:

those who oppose you (NIV)

your enemies (GNT)

will be ashamed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will be ashamed is in the passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

they may be put to shame (ESV)

- Using an active verb. For example:

will feel shame

2:8c
having nothing bad to say about us.

- because there will be nothing evil that he/they can say against us^(incl).
- They will not be able to find any way to criticize us.

having nothing bad to say about us: This clause probably indicates the reason why Titus’ opponents would be ashamed. They would not be able to think of any good reason to criticize Titus and his teaching. If Titus spoke truthfully and acted with integrity, his enemies would end up being ashamed and silent.

Here some other ways to translate this clause:

having nothing evil to say of us (NRSV)

because there is nothing bad to say about us (NCV)

General Comment on 2:7c-8c

The BSB has translated these verse parts as one long sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to translate them as two or more shorter sentences. For example:

^{7c}When you teach, do it with honesty and seriousness. ^{8a}Speak the truth so that you cannot be

criticized. ^{8b}Then those who are against you will be ashamed ^{8c}because there is nothing bad to say about us. (NCV)

Titus 2:9

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

2:9a

Slaves are to submit to their own masters in everything,

- ¶ Teach believing slaves to be respectful of their masters' authority in every way.
- ¶ Teach the slaves in your congregations/churches always to obey their masters.

There is no verb in Greek at the beginning of this verse, but many English versions supply a verb. For example:

Teach slaves to be subject to their masters (NIV)

Urge bondslaves to be subject to their own masters (NASB)

Slaves: This word refers to a person who is legally owned by someone else. In Paul's time it was very common for wealthy people to buy and sell slaves. Sometimes people were captured during war and became slaves. Sometimes they fell into debt and sold themselves to pay it off. The owner of the slave had complete control of his life and could make him do any kind of work without pay. Here Paul was talking about believers who were slaves.

If slaves are unknown in your area, use an expression for someone who is forced to work for no pay.

are to submit to: The Greek word that the BSB translates as submit to means "to be under the authority of." It is the same verb that Paul used in 2:5c when he said women should be "submissive to" their husbands.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to be subject to (NIV)

to respect their master's authority (REB)

to place themselves under (GW)

their own masters: The Greek word that the BSB translates as masters is the regular term for the owner of property.

in everything: There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It belongs with the verb "be subject to" in 2:9a. For example: ^{9a}Urge bondslaves to be subject to their own masters in everything (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NET, ESV, NASB, REB, NJB, NABRE, NCV, GW, NRSVUE)
2. It belongs with the verb "please" in 2:9b. For example: ^{9a}Slaves are to submit to their masters ^{9b}and please them in all things. (GNT) (RSV/NRSV, GNT, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). See Colossians 3:22a, where the phrase in everything must belong with the verb "obey."

2:9b

to be well-pleasing,

- Tell them to try to please/satisfy them,
- Tell them to try to do what will make their masters happy.

to be well-pleasing: This phrase describes behavior that makes the master happy or satisfied.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

try to make their master happy

to give them satisfaction

2:9c

not argumentative,

- not to argue with them,
- They should not argue with them

not argumentative: This Greek verb means "speak against." Here it probably means that the slaves should not argue with their masters or be rude to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

They must not talk back to them (GNT)

not arguing with them (NCV)

Titus 2:10

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

2:10a

not stealing from them,

- and not to steal things from them.
- or take their property/goods.

not stealing from them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stealing means “to put aside for oneself.” Many slaves were trusted by their masters to handle money or other valuable things. Some slaves tried to take some of their masters' property to use for themselves.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

not to steal (NIV)

not pilfering (NET)

They should not steal from them (NCV)

2:10b

but showing all good faith,

- Rather, they must show their masters that they are worthy of trust,
- Instead they should prove to their masters that they are honest.

but: The Greek word here marks a sharp contrast. Here it contrasts stealing with showing oneself to be trustworthy.

showing all good faith: This Greek phrase is more literally “showing all good faithfulness.” It indicates that slaves who believed in Jesus should behave in a trustworthy manner at all times.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They must be completely honest and trustworthy. (CEV)

to show themselves absolutely trustworthy (REB)

but should show their masters they can be fully trusted (NCV)

2:10c

so that in every respect they will adorn the teaching about God our Savior.

- so that their whole way of life/living/behaving will cause people/others to see/realize that the message about God our^(incl) Savior is good.
- They should act like this so that their good/admirable behavior will cause people to respect/admire what we teach about God our Savior.

so that in every respect they will adorn the teaching about God our Savior:

Paul concluded his instructions to slaves by giving the reason why he wanted them to behave in this way. His purpose was that the gospel teaching would be attractive and appealing to unbelievers.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

so as to bring credit to the teaching about God our Savior (GNT)

Then they will show the beauty of the teachings about God our Savior (GW)

in every respect: This is the same Greek phrase as in 2:9a where the BSB translated it as “in everything.”

they will adorn the teaching about God our Savior:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates adorn means “beautify” or “make attractive.” It refers to making a person or a building beautiful by adding decoration. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the teaching about God our Savior refers to the gospel. Christian slaves could help other people appreciate the beauty of the gospel by their behavior toward their masters.

General Comment on 2:9–10

The BSB has followed the Greek punctuation and translated 2:9–10 as one long sentence. In many languages it may be more natural to translate these verses as several shorter sentences. For example:

As for slaves, tell them to obey their masters always. They must not argue with their masters. Instead, they should work well to please their masters. Slaves must not take things that belong to their masters. Their masters should be able to

trust them completely. Then people will respect the message that we teach about God, our Savior. (EASY)

^{9a}Teach slaves to obey their masters in everything they do. ^{9b}Tell them to try to please their masters. ^{9c}They must not talk back to them. ^{10a}They must not steal from them. ^{10b}Instead, they must show that they can be trusted completely. ^{10c}Then they will make the teaching about God our Savior appealing in every way. (NirV)

Titus 2:11

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

Paragraph 2:11–14

In 2:10c Paul mentioned “the teaching about God our Savior.” In this section he describes that teaching in more detail. He discusses the basic things that Christians believe and why they should behave righteously. Jesus offered himself as a sacrifice for our sins, so we should live pure lives and not behave in ways that dishonor God. The new life that Christians now have makes them look forward to the day when Jesus will return.

2:11

For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to everyone.

- ¶ For God has shown his grace by bringing/sending salvation to all people.
- ¶ Teach the believers like this because God has revealed how kind he is and made a way to rescue everyone from sin.

For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to everyone: This verse introduces a new paragraph and a new idea. Paul gave Titus the reason why he should give the preceding instructions to the Christians. Titus should do this because God had sent Jesus Christ to earth to save everyone who believes in him, even though they do not deserve to be saved.

Scholars do not agree about where the words to everyone fit into this sentence. There are two possibilities:

1. The phrase to everyone belongs with the phrase translated as bringing salvation. This is the view of most English versions and commentators. So the meaning is: “God has revealed his kindness by providing a way to save all people.” For example:

For the grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to all people (NASB) (BSB, NIV, NASB, NET, GW, NRSV, NABRE, NCV, NLT, CEV, GNT, NJB)

1. The phrase to everyone belongs with the verb appeared, that is, God's grace has appeared to all people. So the meaning is: “God has revealed to all people his kindness which gives them a way to be saved.” For example:

For the grace of God that brings salvation has appeared to all men. (NIV84) (NIV84, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow the first interpretation (1), along with the majority of English versions and commentaries.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For links this paragraph to the previous verses (2:1–10). It introduces the reason for the instructions that Paul gave in 2:1–10.

the grace of God has appeared: This clause indicates that God's grace has been shown or given to people. That is, God has revealed his grace to people. He has shown them his undeserved kindness and generosity by sending Jesus to be their Savior.

In some languages it may not be possible to make grace the subject of the clause. Instead it may be more natural to make God the subject. For example:

For God has revealed his grace (GNT)

God has shown us clearly how very kind he is (EASY)

God has graciously/freely shown us his kindness/favor

the grace of God: The phrase the grace of God here refers to the kindness that God freely shows to people because he is good and generous. It implies that people have not done anything to deserve this kindness. He himself chooses to help them and show them favor. Some other ways to translate the phrase the grace of God in this context are:

the kindness of God

God's merciful goodness

bringing salvation to everyone: God's grace is shown in the salvation that is made available to all people. The BSB has supplied the verb bringing. Other English translations supply different verbs or phrases. For example:

that offers salvation to all people (NIV)

that can save everyone (NCV)

salvation: This word refers to being rescued from something harmful or dangerous. In Scripture it generally refers to rescue from God's anger at the final judgment.

In some languages it may be necessary to say what people are saved from. If that is true in your language, you should refer to destruction or punishment, that is, the results of sin. For example:

to save/rescue all people from destruction

to save/rescue all people from the final judgment

which frees them from the great punishment of God

Titus 2:12

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

Paragraph 2:11–14

In 2:10c Paul mentioned "the teaching about God our Savior." In this section he describes that teaching in more detail. He discusses the basic things that Christians believe and why they should behave righteously. Jesus offered himself as a sacrifice for our sins, so we should live pure lives and not behave in ways that dishonor God. The new life that Christians now have

makes them look forward to the day when Jesus will return.

2:12a

It instructs us to renounce ungodliness and worldly passions,

- His grace instructs/trains us to reject/refuse all ungodly behavior and worldly desires
- By/Through God's grace, we learn to refuse everything/things that do not honor/please God and to abandon/deny our desires for the good things of this world.

It instructs us to renounce ungodliness and worldly passions:

The subject of this clause (It) is "the grace of God" from 2:11. Paul talks about God's grace as if it were a person who teaches us. This is called "personification." When people realize that God has shown great kindness and favor to them, they will behave in a new way as a result. Knowing God's grace motivates them to reject evil ways (2:12a) and to behave in righteous ways (2:12b). So the grace of God acts as a teacher to these people.

It instructs us: In some languages it is possible to translate this literally: "God's grace instructs us." But in some languages it is impossible to use this sort of personification. If this is a problem in your language, you could translate like this:

By showing us grace/kindness, God teaches us...

Because God has shown us this kindness/favor, we are learning...

us: Here this pronoun is inclusive and refers to Paul, Titus, and all believers.

to renounce: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as renounce means "deny, reject." God's grace teaches his people to reject all evil. It teaches them to stop behaving in ways that do not please God and to refuse to do the things that unbelievers do.

ungodliness: This word refers to doing or saying things that show no reverence or respect for God. Here are other ways to translate this word:

having/showing disrespect for what is holy

doing or saying things that dishonor/disrespect God

worldly passions: The phrase worldly passions refers to strong desires to have or do something related to this world. This could include desires for money, power, and improper sexual relationships. This is in contrast to the Holy Spirit and God's desires for his people. Following these desires results in a person behaving in the way unbelievers behave. The thing the person wants is not always evil, but because the person wants it so much, it causes him to behave in a sinful way and controls the way he behaves.

passions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as passions refers to strong desires of any kind. But in this context, it implies bad desires.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

sinful/evil desires

their inmost cravings

lusts

2:12b

and to live sensible, upright, and godly lives in the present age,

- and to live in a way that is wise, righteous, and pious at this present age/world.
- Instead, in this present time, we learn to behave in a sensible and right way, a way that honors/pleases God.

and to live sensible, upright, and godly lives in the present age: In 2:12a, Paul mentioned two ways in which believers were not to behave, because of God's grace. Now he gives three positive ways they are to behave instead.

sensible: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sensible means "being sensible and moderate in one's behavior." Louw and Nida (88.94). It describes a person who thinks and acts wisely and appropriately in various situations. This word is used in 1:8c to describe an overseer. It is also used in 2:2a, 2:5a, and 2:6. God's grace causes the people of God to show restraint in their behavior and to think and act sensibly.

upright: The Greek word that the BSB translates as upright is often translated as "righteous" in the sense of "living the way we ought to live."

Here are other ways to translate this word:

to do what is right (T4T)

live righteously

live morally

godly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godly means "in a devout and pious way." Someone who lives a godly life is someone who submits himself to God and acts in ways that please God. See how you translated this word in 2 Timothy 3:12a 2Ti3.12a.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

in a way that pleases God

whatever pleases/honors God

in the present age: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the present age means "during this present time," or "during these days" or "while we are living in this world."

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in this world (GNT)

in this evil world

while we live in this world (EASY)

Titus 2:13

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus' return.

Paragraph 2:11–14

In 2:10c Paul mentioned "the teaching about God our Savior." In this section he describes that teaching in more detail. He discusses the basic things that Christians believe and why they should behave righteously. Jesus offered himself as a sacrifice for our sins, so we should live pure lives and not behave in ways that dishonor God. The new life that Christians now have makes them look forward to the day when Jesus will return.

2:13a**as we await the blessed hope and**

- We behave this way while we wait in hope of that wonderful day,
- We do this as we wait for the fulfilment of our joyful hope.

as we await the blessed hope: The Greek more literally says “waiting for the blessed hope.” This verse part indicates the time during which believers are to live holy lives. It is also implied that believers are to live holy lives because they are waiting of the joyful event of Christ’s return. They should say no to sin while they are waiting for Christ to return, and, by implication, because they are waiting for Christ to return.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

waiting for our blessed hope (ESV)

as we wait for the blessed hope

while we look forward with hope to that wonderful day (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

We are filled with hope, as we wait for... (CEV)

We should live like that while we wait for our great hope (NCV)

we: This pronoun is inclusive and refers to Paul, Titus, and all believers.

await: The Greek word that the BSB translates as await means to “welcome,” “receive,” “look forward with expectation” for something or some one. Christians know for certain that Christ will return and they are waiting for his return eagerly.

the blessed hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed is often translated as “happy,” “fortunate,” or “favored.” In this context, the word highlights that this is a very special and significant hope that we as believers have. In some languages it may not be possible to describe an abstract idea like hope as blessed. Instead, it may be more natural to translate this as:

the blessed Day we hope for (GNT)

the hope that brings blessing

the hope that makes us happy

hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope means “confident expectation,” that is, the state of waiting for and expecting something to happen that you are looking forward to. It does not mean that we doubt or wonder if it will happen. See the notes on hope at 1:2a.

In some languages the idea of hope is expressed more clearly as a verb instead of a noun. As a verb it could be expressed like this: “while we wait for the blessed/wonderful event we are hoping for.” The event that we are hoping for is the return of Jesus Christ.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

while we look forward with hope to that wonderful day (NLT)

the happy fulfillment of our hope (NET, REB)

2:13b**glorious appearance of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ.**

- the day when Jesus Christ, our great God and Savior, will return in all his greatness/majesty.
- This hope is that Jesus Christ will appear again with great glory. He is our great God and the one who saves us from our sins.

and glorious appearance of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ: This part of the verse gives the content of the “blessed hope” in 2:13a. The thing Christians hope for is Christ’s return.

glorious: The word glorious refers literally to a very bright light. In this context it refers to the greatness, splendor, and shining radiance that surrounds God.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

majestic

great

appearance: The Greek word that the BSB translates as appearance here refers to the return of Jesus Christ. In some languages it will be easier to translate this as a verb form. For example:

at the time when he appears

when he returns to earth

our great God and Savior Jesus Christ: Here Paul probably referred to Jesus Christ as both our great God and our...Savior. When Paul talks about “the glorious appearing of our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ” in 2:13, he is not saying that our great God will appear, and that our Savior Jesus Christ will also appear. He is saying that Jesus Christ will appear, and he calls Jesus our great God and Savior. The reasons for understanding the phrase in this way are: 1. Both the words God and Savior are in a phrase with just one article in Greek. (An article is the word in Greek that means “of the.”) This means that both God and Savior are joined together by that one grammatical article, and so refer to the same person. 2. The New Testament does not teach that God the Father will come to earth and appear, but it does teach that Jesus will do this. The word translated as “appearance” is also used in other verses about Jesus coming to earth (see 1 Timothy 6:14, 2 Timothy 4:1, 8). 3. The following verse (2:14) refers to Christ alone. So it is logical to assume that this verse (2:13) refers only to him. Translate this in a way that makes this clear. For example:

Jesus Christ, who is our great God and Savior

our: This pronoun is inclusive and refers to all Christians, not just to Paul and Titus.

great: Here the adjective great modifies the word “God” alone to emphasize even more the supreme greatness of God.

Savior: This word refers to someone who rescues people from danger. Jesus as Savior indicates that he rescues believers from the danger of God’s judgment against sinners.

Here are some ways to translate Savior:

rescuer

the person who saves us/you

He is the one who saves us from our sins. (EASY)

the person who saves/rescues from sin/death

General Comment on 2:13a–b

In 2:13a our hope is mentioned, and in 2:13b the object of our hope is made more clear: Jesus Christ himself is our hope. The EASY translation makes this explicit:

We are waiting for Jesus Christ to return to this world. When he comes, that will make us very happy. Everyone will see how great Jesus Christ is. He is our great God. He is the one who saves us from our sins. (EASY)

It may be helpful in your language to use shorter sentences, as in the EASY translation above. Another possibility is:

That’s how we should live as we wait for the blessed hope God has given us. We are waiting for Jesus Christ to appear in his glory. He is our great God and Savior. (NirV)

Titus 2:14

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

Paragraph 2:11–14

In 2:10c Paul mentioned “the teaching about God our Savior.” In this section he describes that teaching in more detail. He discusses the basic things that Christians believe and why they should behave righteously. Jesus offered himself as a sacrifice for our sins, so we should live pure lives and not behave in ways that dishonor God. The new life that Christians now have makes them look forward to the day when Jesus will return.

2:14a

He gave Himself for us

- He gave his life for us
- He died for our sake

He gave Himself for us: The expression gave Himself indicates that Jesus died willingly. He was not forced to make this sacrifice. Here are some other ways to translate this:

He gave his life for us

He was willing to die for us

Paul continued the description of Jesus that he began in the previous verse. In some languages it may be natural to continue the previous sentence here. For example:

who gave himself for us (NIV)

for us: Most scholars understand the phrase for us to mean here “on our behalf.” Christ died to help us, for our benefit.

us: This refers to all Christians, not just to Paul and Titus.

2:14b

to redeem us from all lawlessness

- in order to rescue us from the power of sin
- in order to set us free from all sin.

to redeem us from all lawlessness: This verse part gives the first reason for which Jesus gave his life for us. It is a purpose clause. Jesus’ first purpose was to redeem us, that is, believers from all lawlessness.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to free us from every kind of sin (NLT)

He gave himself to rescue us from every kind of evil (CEV)

to redeem us from all wickedness (NIV)

redeem: The Greek word that the BSB translates as redeem refers to the process of freeing a slave. Here it is used in a figurative sense to refer to Jesus’ death as paying to set us free from the power of sin and death.

us: The pronoun us is again inclusive of Paul, Titus, and all believers.

from all lawlessness: Paul said that Jesus died to redeem us from all lawlessness. This probably means that Jesus has freed his people from having to do any kind of bad thing. They are free to do what is right and good.

all lawlessness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lawlessness refers to not respecting or obeying God’s law. Some other ways to translate all lawlessness are:

all wickedness (NIV)

every sin (GW)

all evil (NIRV)

2:14c

and to purify for Himself a people for His own possession,

- and to remove the sin/sins from/of his people. His purpose/will is for us to belong to him
- He wants to make for himself a pure people to be his own,

and to purify for Himself a people for His own possession: This is the second purpose for which Jesus died. He wanted to make for himself a pure people.

The verb purify here refers here to purifying people from sin. God would forgive the people of their past sins and help them not to want to sin any more. It does not imply that he would wash their bodies. Translate this in a way that is clear in your language. For example:

and to make our hearts pure (CEV)

we can be completely good and clean inside ourselves (EASY)

a people for His own possession: Jesus cleanses people because he wants them to belong to him and to no one else. The words His own possession mean that these people are special to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

He wanted us to be his own people (CEV)

his own special people (EASY)

2:14d

zealous for good deeds.

- and be enthusiastic about doing what is good.
- a people who are very eager to do good works.

zealous for good deeds: When people belong to Jesus, they want very much to do what is good, unlike the false teachers (see 1:16).

zealous: The Greek word that the BSB translates as zealous describes people who are deeply committed to something and enthusiastic about it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

eager (NIV)

totally committed (NLT)

who really/strongly want

enthusiastic (GW)

for good deeds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good deeds is literally “good works.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what is good (NIV)

doing good things (GW)

to do what God considers good

Titus 2:15

Section 2:1–15: Paul told Titus what he should teach about Christian behavior

In this section, Paul explained the behavior that Titus should encourage in various groups of believers. He did not want anyone to say bad things about the word of God based on the behavior of Christians. He also encouraged Titus to let his own behavior be a good example for others. The reason to act in these ways is because the grace of God has appeared to us all, teaching us how to act while we wait for Jesus’ return.

Paragraph 2:15

This next verse (2:15) is a summary statement. In most versions it forms a paragraph by itself. Paul had given Titus some detailed instructions to pass on to the believers and here he told Titus to teach these instructions with full authority.

2:15a

Speak these things

- ¶ So I want you to teach the believers these things that I have written to you.
- ¶ So, Titus, make sure you teach these things to the people there in Crete.

Speak these things: It is possible to understand this as referring to either the things Paul had just told Titus or to what follows. However, most commentators agree that it refers back, that is, to the instructions in 2:2–14.

The Greek text more literally says “These things speak.” This is a direct command to Titus, an imperative. Here are some other ways to translate this:

You must teach these things (NLT)

Declare these things (ESV)

So communicate these things (NET)

Teach the believers these things! (T4T)

2:15b

as you encourage and rebuke with all authority.

- Urge them to do all these things and correct them when they do not do them. You^(sing) have full authority to do so.
- Appeal to the believers to obey your instructions and rebuke those who do not. Remember that God has authorized/commanded you to do this.

as you encourage and rebuke with all authority:

Paul told Titus to do two things when he taught the believers: encourage them and rebuke them. In some languages it may be natural to supply an object that refers to both these verbs. For example:

encourage and rebuke your hearers (GNT)

encourage: The Greek word which the BSB translates encourage means to strengthen and comfort someone, generally by speaking kind words to them. In many languages it may be natural to supply an object, that is, indicate that Titus was to encourage the believers who lived in Crete.

Paul used this same verb in 1:9b and 2:6 where the BSB translates it as “urge” (see the notes on these verses). It means that Titus was to urge the believers to do the things he was teaching them. Some languages have a figure of speech to communicate this. For example, “give liver and intestines”^Ut-Hun Back Translation. is one cultural equivalent for encouraging.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

urge them

strengthen the people^{See Nalik Back Translation, in progress.}

Help them to live in a good way (EASY)

Give the believers encouragement

Speak good/kind words to them

rebuke: To rebuke means to tell people when they are wrong and correct their wrong behavior. This is the same verb that Paul used in 1:13b. See the note there.

In some languages it may be necessary to supply an object and indicate whom Titus was to encourage and rebuke. For example:

tell them what is wrong in their lives (NCV)

correct the believers

with all authority: Paul was reminding Titus that, as a church leader, Titus had the full right or authority to instruct the people under his care in spiritual things.

General Comment on 2:15a-b

The words “with all authority” probably refer to Titus’ teaching in general, that is, to both encouraging and rebuking the believers under his care. It is good to make this clear in your translation. Here are some ways to translate 15a-b in a way that makes this clear:

Teach these things and use your full authority as you encourage and rebuke your hearers. (GNT)

Teach these things, as you use your full authority to encourage and correct people. (CEV)

You must teach these things and encourage your people to do them, correcting them where necessary. You have the authority to do this. (NLT)

2:15c

Let no one despise you.

- Make sure that no one ignores you.
- No one should ignore you.

Let no one despise you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as despise means to consider someone to be unimportant. It can involve ignoring that person and paying no attention to what he says. Paul wrote that Titus must not allow the people under his care to behave as if what he was teaching was unimportant. God had given him the authority to teach (2:15b), and so the people should respect him.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

No one should despise you. (NJB)

Make sure that everyone respects you properly. (EASY)

so don’t let anyone ignore you or disregard what you say (NLT)

Titus 3:1

Section 3:1-11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1-14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1-11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

Paragraph 3:1-2

In this paragraph, Paul told the believers to obey the laws of the government officers. He also gave general instructions about living peacefully and in a humble and kind way with other people.

These two verses form one long sentence in Greek and contain seven instructions for Titus to pass on to the believers on Crete. In some languages it may be natural to divide these verses into several shorter sentences. For example:

¹Remind your people to submit to rulers and authorities, to obey them, and to be ready to do good in every way. ²Tell them not to speak evil of anyone, but to be peaceful and friendly, and always to show a gentle attitude toward everyone. (GNT)

^{1a}Remind the believers to submit to the government and its officers. They should be obedient, always ready to do what is good. ^{2a}They must not slander anyone and must avoid quarreling. Instead, they should be gentle and show true humility to everyone. (NLT)

3:1a**Remind the believers to submit to rulers and authorities, to be obedient**

- ¶ Titus, remind the believers to respect the authority of the government and village leaders and to obey their laws.
- ¶ Titus, tell the people they should remember that they should be under their rulers' authority and do as the authorities tell them to do.

Remind the believers to submit to rulers and authorities: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Remind here indicates that Paul wanted Titus to tell the people to remember something that they already knew.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

Remind your people to submit to rulers and authorities (GNT)

Remind believers to willingly place themselves under the authority of government officials. (GW)

You^(sing) should tell the people there to remember to respect the authority of the various government officials and leaders.

to submit to: The Greek word the BSB translates as submit to means “to be subject to, respect the authority of.” Paul told Titus that Christians must respect the authority of the local (secular) leaders.

rulers and authorities: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as rulers and authorities is more literally “rulers, authorities.”^{3:1} Some Greek manuscripts do contain the word meaning “and,” but the UBS Greek New Testament accepts the reading without the word “and” as probably original, giving it a C rating. The two nouns basically mean the same thing. They refer to government rulers, not church leaders. They include people like the king or president, district officials, village chiefs—anyone who has been appointed or elected as a leader of the community. In some languages it may be natural to translate the two terms rulers and authorities using just one term. For example:

all those who rule

the various government leaders

the authority of government officials (GW)

to be obedient: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to be obedient here indicates that Paul wanted Titus to tell the people to obey their secular rulers. They should do as they were instructed. This word is very similar in meaning to the Greek word translated as “to submit to” in the previous clause.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to obey them (GW)

Believers should obey them. (GW)

General Comment on 3:1a

In some languages it may be natural to combine the commands “submit” and “be obedient.” For example:

^{1a}Diligently obey the commands of those who have authority over you.

3:1b**and ready for every good work,**

- Remind them to be willing/ready to do whatever is good/helpful toward others.
- Remind them they should be prepared to do all good behaviors to other people.

ready for every good work: Paul told Titus to tell the Christians that they must be willing or prepared to do anything that was good and helpful.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

and to be ready to do good in every way (GNT)

always ready to what is good (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

They must always be ready to do something helpful. (CEV)

Titus 3:2**Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers**

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He

once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

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^{1a}Remind the believers to submit to the government and its officers. They should be obedient, always ready to do what is good. ^{2a}They must not slander anyone and must avoid quarreling. Instead, they should be gentle and show true humility to everyone. (NLT)

3:2a

to malign no one,

- They should not speak lies/evil about anyone,
- Remind them they should not criticize any other people.

to malign no one: The Greek word that the BSB translates as malign means “blaspheme/defame/revile.” Titus was to teach that Christians should not speak evil of anyone falsely. See 2:5d and 2:3b.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

to speak no evil about anyone (NCV)

They must not slander anyone (NET)

3:2b

and to be peaceable and gentle,

- but instead live peacefully with other people, and show kindness to them,
- Remind them they should not quarrel/argue with other people but they should be gentle/patient with them.

and to be peaceable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peaceable describes someone who does not quickly or often fight with others. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

to live in peace (NCV)

not...argue (CEV)

to avoid quarrels (REB)

and gentle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentle means “considerate, forbearing, yielding.” It is the opposite of being aggressive. It describes people who are gracious and patient in their behavior toward others and do not demand their own way and their own rights. A modern English term for such people is “mellow.” Here are some other ways to translate this:

kind (NirV)

not demanding their own way

respectful/thoughtful of others

3:2c

showing full consideration to everyone.

- and be truly gentle in their dealings with everyone.
- and they should behave in a completely gentle way toward everyone.

showing full consideration to everyone: The Greek word that the BSB translates as full can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It means that consideration should be complete and shown in all kinds of different ways. For example:

to show perfect courtesy to all people (ESV)

(BSB, RSV/NRSV, NLT, NASB, KJV, NET, ESV, NABRE)

1. It means consideration should be shown at all times. Believers should always show consideration to others. For example:

and always to show a gentle attitude toward everyone (GNT) (NJB, GNT, REB, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow the first option (1). Most scholars understand the word this way. In some languages it may be possible to combine the ideas by using a word meaning “consistent”:

show consistent courtesy/gentleness to all

have a consistently courteous/gentle attitude toward everyone

showing full consideration: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as showing...consideration is literally “showing gentleness.” In some languages it may be more natural to say:

act with gentleness

to everyone: This last phrase to everyone means “in your dealings with everyone.” The idea here is that the believers were to show gentleness and courtesy to their unbelieving pagan neighbors and not just to other Christians.

Titus 3:3

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

3:3a

For at one time we too were foolish, disobedient, misled,

- ¶ Remind them to behave like this because previously we^(incl) were foolish, we disobeyed God, people deceived us
- ¶ I say this because there was a time when we ourselves were foolish, just like unbelievers are now,

we did not obey, people tricked us into behaving in the evil ways they taught.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For is a word that links this paragraph (3:3–7) back to the last paragraph (3:1–2). Paul had just told Titus (in 3:1–2) how the believers should behave and now (3:3–8) he gave the reasons why they should behave in that way, namely that God had been kind and loving to the believers while they were still evil, so now they should likewise be kind and loving to others.

Here is another way to translate this transition word:

Because (T4T)

Some English versions do not translate this word. Do whatever is most natural in your own language.

at one time: The Greek word that the BSB translates as at one time refers to an indefinite time in the past. In this context it means “the time before we became Christians” or “before we believed.” Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In the past (NCV)

Once (NLT)

we too were foolish: The Greek word the BSB translated as foolish means “stupid” or “without understanding.” In this context, it indicates that all these people did not understand spiritual matters.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

we also were foolish (NCV)

we, like them, had no understanding of God’s ways

we: The Greek pronoun the BSB translates as we here is inclusive: Paul included himself and Titus and the believers in Crete. He was as foolish as the Christians in Crete had been.

too: The Greek word that the BSB translates as too here means “also, as well.” Paul and Titus, and the other believers, were all once ignorant of the gospel, just like the pagans among whom they lived, the “everyone” of 3:2c.

disobedient: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disobedient here indicates that these people did

not obey instructions. See note on 1:16c where the same word is used.

Paul did not make explicit whose instructions these people failed to obey. Scholars suggest two options:

1. It refers specifically to disobeying God.
2. It means more general disobedience—disobeying both God and human authorities.

Most English versions leave this ambiguous. You should do the same if that is possible in your language. If, however, in your language you must say whom they were disobeying, it is recommended that you supply “God”:

disobedient to God

did not obey God

mised: The Greek word that the BSB translates as misled is passive in form. Paul probably meant that before the Christians believed in Jesus, other people, or perhaps Satan, lied to them or deceived them to discourage them from believing. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

we were misled

we ourselves were...led astray (NRSV)

- Using an active verb and supplying a subject. For example:

people lied to us

Satan deceived us

3:3b

and enslaved to all sorts of desires and pleasures—

- and we could not stop doing all kinds of evil deeds that we wanted to do and that we enjoyed doing.
- We were like slaves, controlled by a continual desire to do all the evil deeds we enjoyed doing.

and enslaved to all sorts of desires and pleasures:

This verse part indicates that these people used to be slaves to desires and pleasures, that is, they were controlled by them. They were not free to behave in a different way.

This is a passive clause and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

enslaved to various lusts and pleasures (NASB)

- using an active verb. For example:

and became slaves to many lusts and pleasures (NLT)

Translate this using the verb form that is most natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to leave the verb implied:

slaves to various passions and pleasures

all sorts of desires and pleasures: The Greek adjective that the BSB translates as all sorts of means “various.” It refers to both desires and pleasures. These desires and pleasures affected not just one area of life but many areas of life.

desires: The Greek word that the BSB translates as desires implies a desire to do something evil or immoral, so it can also be translated “passions” or “lust.”

pleasures: This word is similar in meaning to “desires.” It refers to all kinds of enjoyable activities, illegal or immoral as well as legal and moral, whatever gives pleasure.

3:3c

living in malice and envy,

- We spent our time behaving in evil/wicked ways and envying other people.
- We were mean/bad to people and we hated people who had advantages over us.

living in malice and envy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as living in means “passing our lives” or “spending our time.” Paul was saying that before people became Christians, they spent their time doing malicious and envious things. Here are some other ways to translate this:

spending our life in malice and envy (NASB)

We spent our lives doing evil and being jealous. (NCV)

Our lives were full of evil and envy. (NLT)

malice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as malice is a general word referring to evil or wickedness.

envy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as envy refers to the desire to possess something that someone else has, that is, the desire for your own well-being rather than that of the other person. This is the action forbidden by the Tenth Commandment, “You shall not covet.”

3:3d

being hated and hating one another.

- We were hated by other people and we hated each other too.
- People hated us and we hated people too.

being hated and hating one another: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as being hated is an adjective that describes something as worthy of hate, that is, hateful. There are several ways to translate it:

- As a verb. For example:

others hated us and we hated them (GNT)

- As an adjective. For example:

hateful (NASB)

despicable (NRSV)

Here is another way to translate this verse part:

We behaved in a way that caused people to hate us, and we hated one another.

Titus 3:4

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

3:4–7

After writing about the way that they used to live before they became Christians, Paul now reminded

Titus that things had changed because of what God had done for them. He emphasized that God did not save them because of the good deeds they had done. He saved them because he was merciful.

Verses 3:4–7 are one sentence in Greek, but probably you will need to use several sentences in your translation. See the General Comment at the end of 3:7.

3:4

But when the kindness of God our Savior and His love for mankind appeared,

- But God our^(incl) Savior revealed to us his kindness and his love for us,
- However, God our Savior showed us that he is kind and loves us/everyone.

But: What Paul was now going to say contrasts with 3:3. Before people became Christians, their state was as Paul had described it in 3:3. Now since God had saved them everything had changed for them. In English this contrast is shown by the use of But. Use whatever word or structure you use in your language to indicate this sort of contrast.

when the kindness of God our Savior and His love for mankind appeared:

Most commentators think that Paul was referring here to God sending Jesus to earth. God showed his kindness and love to people by sending Jesus. In some languages it may not be possible to talk about abstract concepts like kindness and love appearing. In those languages it may be more natural to say that they were revealed, or that God showed them to us. For example:

when God our Savior revealed his kindness and love (NLT)

when the kindness and love of God our Savior for humanity were revealed (NJB)

when the kindness and love of God our Savior was shown to us

God our Savior showed us how good and kind he is (CEV)

kindness of God our Savior and His love for mankind:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as kindness means “goodness, generosity.” The Greek word translated as love has a similar meaning and refers to the love God has for people. In some languages it may be natural to translate both these abstract nouns as adjectives. For example:

that he/God is kind and loving

how good and kind he is (CEV)

God our Savior: This phrase refers to God as the one who saves/rescues us from sin and God's wrath.

Titus 3:5

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

3:5a

He saved us,

- and/when he saved/rescued us^(incl).
- He delivered us from our sins.

He saved us: In Greek the verb that the BSB translates as saved is the main verb of this long sentence (3:4–7). The pronoun He refers to God our Savior, from 3:4. The pronoun us refers to Paul, Titus, and all believers, all God's people.

3:5b

not by the righteous deeds we had done,

- He did this, not because we had done righteous works/things
- He did not do this because of anything good that we had done.

not by the righteous deeds we had done: This verse part explains that God did not save his people on the grounds of any good works that they had done. Their righteous acts were not the cause of or reason for their salvation. They did nothing to contribute to it. Their salvation is not a reward for their good deeds.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

it was not because of any upright actions we had done ourselves (NJB)

not on the basis of deeds which we did in righteousness (NASB)

not because we had done righteous deeds

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He did not save us because of any righteous things we had done

It wasn't because of the good things we had done. (NIRV)

righteous deeds we had done: This phrase is more literally "works that we did in righteousness." Paul did not make it clear whether or not people had in fact ever done any righteous deeds. Try to leave this open or ambiguous. For example:

any good deeds that we have done

good things we might have done

righteous deeds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as righteous deeds refers to behaving or acting in righteous ways, deeds done in obedience to God's laws. Other ways to translate this include:

upright actions (NJB)

good works/deeds

things that are good in God's sight

3:5c

but according to His mercy,

- but because he had compassion on us.
- Rather, he did this, because he is merciful.

but according to His mercy: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces a strong contrast. Paul now gave the real or true reason why God acted to save us. The reason was his own mercy. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Rather, he saved us because he had mercy on us.

No, it was because of his mercy that he saved us.

His mercy: This phrase refers to God's mercy, that is, God's compassion for us. In some languages it may be

natural to translate this as a clause with a verb. For example:

God had mercy on us

God showed us kindness

General Comment on 3:5a-c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in these verse parts and put the positive statement first (5c) and the negative second (5b). God saved us because of his mercy. It was not because of our good deeds that he saved us. For example:

^{5a}He saved us ^{5c}because of his mercy. ^{5b}It was not because of the righteous things that we had done.

3:5d

through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit.

- He did this by washing us, so giving us new birth, and by renewing us by the Holy Spirit.
- We received this salvation/deliverance because he cleansed us and in this way gave us new life, and because he gave us the Holy Spirit to cause us to live in a new way.

through the washing of new birth and renewal by the Holy Spirit: In Greek this complex phrase can be understood in a number of different ways. Here are the main options:

1. The Holy Spirit is the agent of one action, renewal. God saved people by means of two things: the washing of new birth and the renewal that was given or caused by the Holy Spirit. For example:

through the washing of the new birth and the renewing of the Holy Spirit (NET)

1. The Holy Spirit is the agent of two actions (new birth, renewal). God saved people by means of one thing: washing them. This washing can be explained or understood as the new birth and renewal of the Holy Spirit. For example:

through the washing in which the Holy Spirit gives us new birth and renewal (GW)

1. The Holy Spirit is the agent of three actions (washing, new birth, renewal). God saved people through these three actions of the Holy Spirit. For example:

through the Holy Spirit, who gives us new birth and new life by washing us (GNT)

All these options have wide support among scholars, and all can be defended from the Greek sentence structure. Some English translations (such as the BSB) are ambiguous or unclear. These Notes and Display follow interpretation (1).3:5 See Knight, The Pastoral Epistles.

through: The Greek word that the BSB translates as through here introduces the means by which God saves people. Following interpretation (1) above, there are two means: “washing of rebirth” and “renewal by the Holy Spirit.”3:5 The Greek text does not contain the definite article “the” anywhere in this phrase. It has been supplied by the BSB. In some languages it may be best to omit it. So in some languages it may be natural to repeat the word through and translate the entire phrase as:

through washing of rebirth and through renewal by/of the Holy Spirit

the washing of new birth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as washing here means “cleansing.” It probably refers to inward cleansing, that is, to purifying people from sin. This washing or cleansing is symbolized by baptism. The phrase washing of new birth probably identifies washing as a new birth, that is, inward cleansing is a kind of rebirth, or results in new birth. For example:

cleansing us, causing us to receive new birth

new birth: The Greek word that the BSB translated as new birth means “new beginning.” This word also occurs in Matthew to refer to the new creation. In this context it refers to the new beginning in someone’s life when they receive new life and become a Christian. Other NT writers use the figure of speech “born again” to refer to the event of becoming a Christian (John 3:3; 1 Peter 1:3, 1:23). If you have already translated these passages, check the expression you used there before deciding what to do here. Other ways to translate this include:

God gave us new birth/life

God enabled us to begin to live in a new way

God caused us to follow a new path

renewal: The Greek word the BSB translates as renewal means “new beginning” in the sense of “a fresh start.” This word also occurs in Romans 12:2. In this context it has a similar meaning to “new birth.” The difference between the two is that the word for “new birth” indicates the starting point of new life, and the word for renewal refers to the new type of life that results from that new birth. Here are some other ways to translate this:

new life (GNT)

making us/believers new people

by the Holy Spirit: As described in the note earlier in this verse part, scholars do not agree as to which action or actions Paul was referring as performed by the Holy Spirit. It is recommended that you translate this as referring to the action of “renewal,” that is, the Holy Spirit is the one who renews God’s people.

Titus 3:6

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

3:6a

This is the Spirit He poured out on us abundantly

- He caused this/his Holy Spirit to stream/come down on us in full measure
- God gave us the Holy Spirit richly/abundantly

This is the Spirit He poured out on us abundantly:

In Greek the sentence continues here using a pronoun that refers to the Holy Spirit. In some languages it may be natural to make this reference explicit and begin a new sentence here, as does the BSB. More examples:

God poured out the Spirit generously

God caused this Holy Spirit to descend upon us in abundance/fullness/richness

He poured out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as poured out is a figure of speech that describes the way God gave the Holy Spirit to his people. This same figure of speech is used in Acts 2:17–18, 33. To “pour out” something is to let it flow or come down. This figure of speech indicates that God caused the Holy Spirit to come down, descend, upon his people.

abundantly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abundantly means “richly, in full measure.” In this context it indicates that God gave the Holy Spirit to believers without holding back, that is, fully or completely. Here are some other ways to translate this:

in God’s great generosity

generously

completely

3:6b

through Jesus Christ our Savior,

- through our^(incl) Savior Jesus Christ.
- because of the work of Jesus Christ, the one who saves us.

through Jesus Christ our Savior: This “pouring out” of the Holy Spirit (3:6a) was done through Jesus Christ our Savior. Commentators understand this in two ways:

1. The life and death of Jesus saved us and made it possible for God to pour out the Holy Spirit. For example:

He generously poured out the Spirit upon us because of what Jesus Christ our Savior did. (NLT)

1. God sent Jesus to give us his Spirit. For example:

God sent Jesus Christ to give us his Spirit. (CEV)

Both of these statements are true. Paul may have had either or both in mind. If you must choose between them, it is recommended that you choose interpretation (1), since Paul referred to Jesus Christ as our Savior.

General Comment on 3:6a–b

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder these parts. For example:

^{6b}Because Jesus Christ died to become our Savior,

^{6a}God has caused the Holy Spirit to come down upon us in full/generous measure.

Titus 3:7

Section 3:1-11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1-14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1-11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

3:7a-c

There are two main ways to understand the structure of 3:7a-c:

1. The words “having been justified” indicate the basis or grounds for God making us his heirs. For example:

And so, since we have been justified by his grace, we become heirs with the confident expectation of eternal life (NET) (BSB, NIV, ESV, KJV, NASB, NET, NRSV, REB, NCV, NJB)

1. The words “having been justified” are part of God’s purpose. For example:

so that we might be justified by his grace

and become heirs in hope of eternal life (NABRE) (CEV, GNT, GW, NLT, RSV, NABRE, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which has the strongest commentary support.^{3:7} See the following commentaries: NIVAC, NIGTC, CBC, AYB, ICC, PNTC, NICNT, REBC. God’s main purpose for saving us and giving us the Holy Spirit was to make us his heirs (3:7b). The action talked about in the words “having been justified by his grace” is another way of referring to the action “he saved us” in 3:5a and 5d. That is, God “justified” us when he saved us and before he made us his “heirs.” Make this clear in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

God did this and ^{7a}declared us righteous in order that ^{7b}we might become his heirs/children ^{7c}and have the hope/expectation to live forever.

God saved us, ^{7a}declaring us right with him, in order that ^{7c}we might become his heirs/children ^{7c}and confidently expect to live with him forever.

3:7a

so that, having been justified by His grace,

- So by his grace/kindness to us, God has declared us^(incl) to be righteous in his sight
- Therefore, because God has chosen to be kind to us and make/put us right with him,

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that here introduces a purpose clause. It indicates God’s purpose, that is, the result that God intended when he saved us (3:5d) and/or poured out his Spirit on us (3:6b). In Greek the same sentence continues throughout 3:4-7 and it is hard to be sure which idea was primary for Paul.

God’s purpose or intended result is given in 3:7b-c (so that “...we might become heirs, having the hope of eternal life”). See the note on 3:7a-c above.

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. If that is the case in your language, you could begin with a general introductory phrase. For example:

God did this so that

having been justified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as having been justified means “declared just” or “made right with God.” See how you translated this in Romans 2:13b, 3:24a, 5:1a, and 8:30b.

This is a passive verb and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

put right with God (GNT)

declared righteous

being made right with God (NCV)

- Using an active verb with God supplied as the subject. For example:

God...has given us his approval (GW)

God has acquitted us of our sins

God said to us, “I no longer hold you guilty of the sins you have committed.”

by His grace: This phrase indicates that God was gracious and generous. He declared us just and made us right with him. We did nothing to deserve or earn that. Other ways to translate this include:

in his kindness (GW)

Because of his grace (NLT)

3:7b

we would become heirs

- and we have become his children
- we have the position of sons/children

we would become heirs: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as we would become heirs gives the purpose for which God saved us and gave us his Holy Spirit (5d). The phrase “so that” from 3:7a is connected to this clause. This was God’s purpose or intended result, and so it certainly will take place.

we: This pronoun is inclusive. Paul included himself, Titus, and the believers in Crete and elsewhere.

heirs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heirs is a figure of speech. It indicates that, just as children can expect to inherit things from their parents, so a person who becomes God’s child can expect to receive eternal life from him.

Christians are often called God’s heirs (see Romans 8:17, Galatians 4:7, Hebrews 6:17, James 2:5). Try to translate this idea in the same way in each of these passages.

3:7c

with the hope of eternal life.

- and confidently expect to live with him forever.
- and we are waiting for him to give us eternal life.

with the hope of eternal life: The Greek is more literally “according to the hope of eternal life.” As God’s heirs (3:7b), believers can confidently expect to receive the eternal life that God has promised to give them. Here are some other ways to translate this:

in hope of eternal life (NJB)

who have the confidence that we have everlasting life (GW)

hope: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hope refers to a confident hope or expectation. Believers wait for God to give them eternal life, trusting that that is what he will do. Since it is God’s purpose in saving them, it will certainly happen.

eternal life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as eternal life refers to life forever with God. This can also be translated as:

the life that never ends (NCV)

General Comment on 3:7a-c

This verse has a complicated grammatical structure, and there are a number of ways of understanding exactly how the different phrases fit together. The basic meaning is that since believers are saved and justified by grace, they are God’s heirs, and as God’s heirs they can confidently expect that they will receive eternal life.

Here are some ways to translate and connect these verse parts:

Because of his grace he made us right in his sight and gave us confidence that we will inherit eternal life. (NLT)

so that by his grace we might be put right with God and come into possession of the eternal life we hope for (GNT)

And so, since we have been justified by his grace, we become heirs with the confident expectation of eternal life. (NET)

General Comment on 3:4-7

In Greek 3:4-7 forms one long sentence. In many languages it may be natural to break this up into several shorter sentences. For example:

⁴When God our Savior revealed his kindness and love, ⁵he saved us, not because of the righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy. He washed away our sins, giving us a new birth and new life through the Holy Spirit. ⁶He generously poured out the Spirit upon us through Jesus Christ our Savior. ⁷Because of his grace he made us right in his sight and gave us confidence that we will inherit eternal life. (NLT)

Titus 3:8

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

Paragraph 3:8

3:8 provides a link between paragraph 3:3–7 and the next paragraph, 3:9–11. It concludes the teachings in 3:4–7 with an assurance that these teachings are true and a command to Titus to emphasize them. Then, in 3:8d, Paul said that these teachings were “excellent and profitable,” in contrast with the “foolish” and “pointless” teachings he would talk about in 3:9–11.

Different translations start the new paragraph at different places. Because this paragraph is a link between two other paragraphs, it may be best to make it a paragraph by itself, as a number of English versions have done (for example, GNT, NCV). You should put the paragraph breaks wherever is most helpful to your readers.

3:8a

This saying is trustworthy.

- ¶ These words are dependable/reliable.
- ¶ You can trust these words.

This saying is trustworthy: This phrase refers back to what Paul has just written, probably 3:4–7, but possibly 3:1–7. Here are some other ways to translate this:

This is doctrine that you can rely on. (NJB)

saying: The Greek word that the BSB translates as saying is literally “word, message.” It refers to what Paul had just been writing in the previous paragraph. It does not refer to just one word or one statement.

trustworthy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as trustworthy means “reliable,” “sure,” “certain to be true,” “something you can trust.” Paul was telling Titus that he could depend on and trust what he has just told him.

3:8b

And I want you to emphasize these things,

- And I want you to place emphasis on these matters when you teach people
- You should keep on emphasizing them.

And I want you: The phrase that the BSB translates as And I want you is a way of introducing a request or polite command. You can translate it as:

And so I request that

And so you should

And please

to emphasize: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to emphasize means “to insist on” or “to stress.” This verb is in the present tense, which means that Paul wanted Titus to do this frequently or regularly, that is, to keep on emphasizing these matters.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate to whom Titus was “to emphasize these things.” If this is the case in your language, you could say that Titus was to emphasize these teachings to the believers in Crete, who are mentioned in the following verse part, 3:8c. For example:

I want you to insist on these things to those who have trusted in God

these things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as these things refers back to the same teachings as 3:8a, that is, the teachings Paul had just given in 3:4–7. You can also translate this phrase as:

these matters

these teachings

these instructions

3:8c

so that those who have believed God will take care to devote themselves to good deeds.

- so that those who believe in God will focus their attention on doing good works.
- Then those people who have trusted in God will concentrate on doing good behavior.

so that: The Greek word the BSB translates as so that here introduces the purpose or desired result of Paul’s instructions. Paul wanted Titus to emphasize his

teachings in order that the believers in Crete would live in a right way.

those who have believed God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who have believed God refers to Christian believers in Crete. They were people who had trusted God to save them through Jesus Christ. If you have supplied an explicit description of them in 3:8b, here you may just refer back to them with a pronoun such as “they/them.”

will take care to devote themselves to good deeds: This long phrase indicates that Paul wanted the believers to think seriously about how to practice good works. He wanted them to consider carefully how they could do good to others and make a strong effort to do so.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

will be careful to use their lives for doing good (NCV)

will be sure to do good deeds (CEV)

may be intent on engaging in good works (NET)

to good deeds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as good deeds is literally “good works.” See the comment on this in the note on 2:7a.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

good works (NJB)

good things (GW)

good deeds (GNT)

3:8d

These things are excellent and profitable for the people.

- These teachings are good and helpful to everyone.
- The things that I have just written are good and useful for all the people/believers there.

These things are excellent and profitable for the people: The Greek word that the BSB translates as These things refers to the advice and doctrinal truths that Paul had written about in the preceding verses, 3:4–7, or possibly 3:1–7. Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

These things are good and will help everyone. (NCV)

These things are good and beneficial for all people. (NET)

excellent: The Greek word that the BSB translates as excellent means “good.”

profitable: The Greek word that the BSB translates as profitable means “helpful, useful, beneficial.”

for the people: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for the people is literally “for men.” This is, however, a use of “men” that refers to people in general.

Titus 3:9

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

Paragraph 3:9–11

In this paragraph Paul gave his final instructions to Titus and the Christians on the island of Crete. He told them to avoid foolish arguments and to avoid people who cause division among Christians.

3:9a

But avoid foolish controversies, genealogies, arguments, and quarrels about the law,

- ¶ But avoid pointless discussions, debates about genealogies, arguments, and quarrels about the Jewish law.
- ¶ But stay away from people who argue about stupid things, people who argue about lists of ancestors, people who like to argue, and people who quarrel about the law that God gave to Moses.

But: The word But indicates that verse 3:9 contrasts with the previous verses. In 3:4–8 Paul wrote about parts of the Christian faith that were “excellent and profitable” for everyone. But now he will talk about things that are not excellent or profitable for people.

avoid foolish controversies, genealogies, arguments, and quarrels about the law: Paul lists four

things that Titus should avoid. None of these are physical items. They all refer to actions that Titus should not get involved in. So in some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb or verbs. For example:

do not get involved in foolish controversies, in discussing genealogies, or in arguing and quarreling about the law

do not take part in foolish arguments about controversial things and family histories. Do not argue or quarrel about the law.

foolish controversies: Titus must avoid foolish controversies. These are foolish issues that people argue about unnecessarily.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

stupid arguments (GNT)

foolish discussions (NLT)

genealogies: Paul told Titus to avoid genealogies. A “genealogy” is a list of the names of ancestors.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

lists of ancestors

family histories

Paul did not condemn all genealogies. The Bible contains many genealogies. It seems that Paul wanted Titus not to argue about genealogies. We do not know exactly which genealogies Paul was talking about, but it was something to do with religion, and something that people studied and argued about. Some commentators think that the false teachers in Crete studied the Jewish genealogies in the Old Testament and tried to find secret meaning in them. Other commentators think that the false teachers studied lists of names of angels and other supernatural beings that they thought could help them reach God.

In 1 Timothy 1:4 Paul spoke to Timothy about a similar problem with genealogies.

arguments, and quarrels about the law: The law here refers to the Jewish law, the law that God gave to Moses. The words arguments and quarrels are similar in meaning. Both words refer to fighting with words,

not physical fighting. If your language does not have two words for arguments and quarrels you can combine them and say:

arguments about the Jewish law

3:9b

because these things are pointless and worthless.

- These are not helpful or useful.
- Avoid these arguments because they do not help anyone. They are of no benefit to anyone.

because these things are pointless and worthless:

In 3:8 Paul said that Christian teachings were “excellent and profitable.” Now, in contrast, he said that arguing about unimportant things was pointless and worthless.

In some languages it may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. Also, you may want to repeat the main verb “avoid.” For example:

Avoid these arguments because they do not help anyone and are useless.

because: The word because here introduces the reason why Titus must avoid meaningless arguments. He must avoid them because they do not help anyone and they are of no use.

pointless: The word pointless means “of no help.” Things that are pointless do not help us to grow in the Christian faith. This is the opposite of the word translated as “profitable” in 3:8d.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

they do not help us to grow in the faith

nothing is gained from them

worthless: The word worthless means “useless” or “futile.” It is similar in meaning to “pointless.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

useless

empty

a waste of time (NLT)

Titus 3:10

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

Paragraph 3:9–11

In this paragraph Paul gave his final instructions to Titus and the Christians on the island of Crete. He told them to avoid foolish arguments and to avoid people who cause division among Christians.

3:10a

Reject a divisive man

- Do not have anything more to do with a person who makes the believers divide into groups.
- You must stay away from people who cause divisions among you.

Reject a divisive man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Reject means “keep/stay away from.” This need not refer to a formal process of excluding the person from the church (excommunication).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

break off contact with a heretic (NAB)

have nothing more to do with anyone who causes divisions (NRSV)

do not be involved with divisive people any more

turn away from a divisive person

a divisive man: A divisive man is someone who likes to argue a lot and encourages other people to argue and break relationships with those who disagree. Paul was not talking about a specific person. He wanted Titus to warn any and all people who caused divisions in the church. So in some languages it may be natural to use a plural form. For example:

Reject people who cause divisions among you

3:10b

after a first and second admonition,

- Do this after you have warned him on two separate occasions.
- But first tell them to stop and if they do not stop tell them again.

after a first and second admonition: Paul told Titus that he should warn these people twice before taking stronger action. If the person did not change the way he was behaving after Titus had warned the person a second time, Titus must “reject” the person.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Warn him once and then warn him again.

Tell them once and if they do not stop tell them again.

Titus 3:11

Section 3:1–11: Christians should live good lives among unbelievers

This section contains the last major theme in this letter. In 2:1–14, Paul had discussed relationships between Christians. Now in 3:1–11, he wrote about relationships that Christians have with non-Christians. He once more gave Titus instructions to pass on to the believers: they must submit to government authorities, be kind to other people, and not participate in useless arguments. God has given them new life because of what Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit have done, and they should live in peace and be generous to others.

Paragraph 3:9–11

In this paragraph Paul gave his final instructions to Titus and the Christians on the island of Crete. He told them to avoid foolish arguments and to avoid people who cause division among Christians.

3:11a

knowing that such a man is corrupt and sinful;

- You can be sure that people like this have turned away from what is right and are sinning.
- You can be confident that these people are deliberately following the wrong way.

knowing that such a man is corrupt and sinful: The term such a man refers to any divisive person, any person who will not listen to Titus’ warnings. Paul was not talking about a specific person, but about any and all people who caused divisions in the church. So in some languages it may be natural to use a plural form. For example:

You may be sure that such people are warped and sinful (NIV)

corrupt: The Greek word that the BSB translates as corrupt describes people who are not upright and straightforward in their character and behavior. Figuratively speaking, they are twisted.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

warped (NIV)

perverted (RSV)

deviated from what is right (NASB)

sinful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sinful is a verb that describes someone who habitually or regularly sins.

3:11b

he is self-condemned.

- They have judged themselves.
- Their own deeds prove that they are guilty.

he is self-condemned: This type of person condemns himself by the way he behaves. This means that the sinful things that these people do make it clear to everyone that they are sinners, in the wrong. Their sinful behavior shows what sort of people they are and proves that that they are in the wrong.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

their own sins show how guilty they are (CEV)

their sins prove that they are wrong (GNT)

condemned by their own actions (GW)

Titus 3:12

Section 3:12–15: Final instructions and greetings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concludes the letter with instructions about Titus' situation, closing greetings, and a blessing.

3:12a

As soon as I send Artemas or Tychicus to you,

- ¶ I will send either Artemas or Tychicus to you on Crete. After that
- ¶ I want to send someone to replace you in your work. It will be either Artemas or Tychicus.

As soon as I send Artemas or Tychicus to you: Paul planned to send either Artemas or Tychicus to go to Crete. When Paul wrote this letter he had not yet sent either of these men. He had not yet decided which one to send. Paul was referring to the time when the one he chose would arrive in Crete. Here are some other ways to translate this:

Later I will send either Artemas or Tychicus to take your place. As soon as he arrives...

Later I will send Artemas or Tychicus to you. As soon as that one meets you...

I send Artemas or Tychicus: Paul intended to ask Artemas or Tychicus to go to Crete. He expected that they would do as he asked. In your translation, use a verb that refers to asking someone to make a trip or do a task. For example:

I tell either Artemas or Tychicus to go

I ask either Artemas or Tychicus to go

I cause either Artemas or Tychicus to go

Artemas: This man is not mentioned anywhere else in the Bible.

Tychicus: This is most likely the same Tychicus mentioned in Acts 20:4; Colossians 4:7; Ephesians 6:21; and 2 Timothy 4:12.

3:12b

make every effort to come to me at Nicopolis,

- do your best to come to me right away at the city of Nicopolis.
- After they arrive, please try hard to come to meet me at Nicopolis.

make every effort to come to me at Nicopolis: The phrase make every effort means “do your best.” Paul wanted Titus to try to join him at the city of Nicopolis on the Greek coast. Crete was an island. So Titus would have to make a voyage by sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse part:

hurry to visit me in the city of Nicopolis (GW)

join me at Nicopolis as soon as you can (REB)

Nicopolis: Nicopolis was a city on the coast of Greece, northwest of Athens.

3:12c

because I have decided to winter there.

- For I have decided to spend the winter months there.
- For that is where I have decided to go and stay during the winter.

because I have decided to winter there: Paul had decided to spend the winter months in Nicopolis. Ships usually did not travel on the Mediterranean Sea during the winter months of November through March because of stormy weather. Paul needed to find a place where he could spend those months.

When Paul wrote this letter, he was not yet in Nicopolis. If you need to make this clear in your translation, you could say:

because I have decided that I will go there and stay there during the winter

because that is where I will go to spend the winter

to winter: This phrase means “to pass the winter months.” If you do not have “winter” in your part of the world, here are two translation possibilities to consider:

- Use a phrase that mentions the cold. For example:

spend the cold season

- Use a phrase that mentions stormy weather. Refer to a time when it rains a lot, or a time when it is most difficult to travel by sea.

spend the rainy season

Titus 3:13

Section 3:12–15: Final instructions and greetings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concludes the letter with instructions about Titus’ situation, closing greetings, and a blessing.

3:13a

Do your best to equip Zenas the lawyer and Apollos,

- When the lawyer named Zenas and another man named Apollos leave on their journey, do whatever you can to help them.

Do your best to equip Zenas the lawyer and Apollos: Paul wanted Titus to help Zenas and Apollos while

they traveled. It is not clear where Zenas and Apollos were when Paul was writing this letter. There are two possibilities:

- These two men were with Paul and he knew that they were soon going to Crete. Possibly they were the ones who took this letter to Titus. Most commentators hold this view.
- These two men were on Crete with Titus, and that they were about to leave on a trip. A few commentators hold this view.

In your translation, try not to be specific about where these men were because Paul did not give us this information.

Do your best: This translates the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “make every effort” in 3:12b. Paul wanted Titus to try hard to help these two men.

to equip: This phrase refers to helping travelers as they set out on a journey. See Acts 15:3; and 1 Corinthians 16:6.

Zenas the lawyer: Zenas is not mentioned anywhere else in the Bible. If you do not have a word for lawyer in your language, you could say “law expert,” or “person who is an expert in the civil law.” This was his profession. Zenas was probably working in the field of Roman civil law, not the Jewish religious law, the law of Moses.

Apollos: Most scholars think that this is the Apollos mentioned in Acts 18:24 and in 1 Corinthians 3:4–22. Spell his name the same way in each of these places.

3:13b

so that they will have everything they need.

- Make sure that they have whatever they need for their journey.
- Give them whatever they need, so they will not lack anything as they travel.

so that they will have everything they need: The Greek phrase is more literally “so that nothing to them is lacking.” Paul asked Titus to give Zenas and Apollos everything they needed for their journey. This might include money, food, and clothing.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

see that they lack nothing (RSV)

make sure that they have everything that they need for their journey (EASY)

Titus 3:14

Section 3:12–15: Final instructions and greetings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concludes the letter with instructions about Titus' situation, closing greetings, and a blessing.

3:14a

And our people must also learn to devote themselves to good works

- As well as this, our^(incl) fellow-believers there on Crete should continually work hard at doing good deeds
- Not only should you do that, but keep on teaching the believers to focus their attention on doing good works

And our people must also learn to devote themselves to good works: The Greek text connects verse 14 to verse 13 with a conjunction that means “more-over also.” Paul told Titus that not only was he to help Zenas and Apollos, but the other believers on Crete were to help people also. You should connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Our people should also learn how to set an example by doing good things (GW)

And our own people must be taught to devote themselves to good works (REB)

And our people must also learn: Paul implied that someone must teach the believers. However, he did not say who was to teach them. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using a passive verb. For example:

Our people must be taught

And our people: This phrase refers to the Christian believers on Crete. The pronoun our is inclusive of Paul and Titus. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

our fellow believers

our brothers and sisters in Christ

to devote themselves to good works: This is the same phrase that the BSB translated as “to devote themselves to good deeds” in 3:8c. Paul said that the

Christians must learn to give their full attention to doing good works.

to good works: The Greek phrase is literally “to engage in good works” (see the notes on 2:7a). Doing good works is one of the main themes of this letter. Paul discussed it in 1:16, 2:7, 2:14, 3:1, and 3:8.

3:14b

in order to meet the pressing needs of others,

- to help people who lack the necessities of life.
- for people who lack basic/necessary things such as food and clothing.

in order to meet the pressing needs of others:

The Greek phrase is more literally “for the necessary needs.” This shows the kind of “good works” that Paul wanted the Cretan Christians to do. They should give help to people who lacked basic necessities such as food, clothes, or housing.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

when urgent needs arise (GW)

in order to provide for urgent needs (NIV)

in order to provide for real needs (GNT)

3:14c

so that they will not be unfruitful.

- They should not live useless lives.
- If they do this, their lives will be useful/purposeful.

so that they will not be unfruitful: This clause gives Paul's purpose in giving these directions to Titus. He did not want the believers to live unfruitful, that is, unproductive, lives. If the believers helped others, they would not be unfruitful, that is, their lives would be useful and have a purpose.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that they may not be unproductive (NRSV)

they should not live useless lives (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive purpose. For example:

so that their lives would be fruitful

so that they can live productive lives (GW)

Titus 3:15

Section 3:12–15: Final instructions and greetings

This is the final section of the letter. Paul concludes the letter with instructions about Titus' situation, closing greetings, and a blessing.

Paragraph 3:15

This is the closing of the letter. The greetings are similar to the greetings at the end of other New Testament letters.

3:15a

All who are with me send you greetings.

- ¶ All the believers here with me greet you^(sing).
- ¶ All my companions send you best wishes.

All who are with me send you greetings: Paul said that all the believers in the area where he was located wanted to greet Titus.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Everybody here sends greetings (NLT)

everyone who is with me says that they are thinking affectionately about you (T4T)

Some languages may have an idiom that expresses the idea of a greeting. For example:

Everyone with me sends respectful words to you

Everyone with me wants me to ask if you are well

Everyone with me asks about the news of you

Use an idiom or form that is appropriate in your language.

3:15b

Greet those who love us in the faith.

- We^(excl) ask you^(sing) to greet our^(incl) fellow believers there on Crete who love us^(excl).
- Give^(sing) warm greetings to those who love us in the faith of Christ Jesus.

Greet those who love us in the faith: Paul asked Titus to pass on his greetings to the other Christians on Crete.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Greet all our friends who share in our faith (CEV)

Give my greetings to the believers—all who love us (NLT)

Greet the fellow Christians on Crete who love us^(excl)

3:15c

Grace be with all of you.

- May the grace of God be with you all.
- May God bless all of you^(plur) there in Crete.

Grace be with all of you: This was a common way to end a letter to fellow Christians. See similar expressions in Ephesians 6:24; Colossians 4:18; 1 Timothy 6:21; 2 Timothy 4:22; Hebrews 13:25. If you have already translated those letters, check how you translated the ending of those letters.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I pray that God will give his grace to all of you.

Grace: As he did at the beginning of the letter (1:4b), Paul is using Grace as a Christian blessing. In this context, avoid using a long phrase to translate Grace.